THE GIFTS OF THE SPIRIT

* Blue denotes ppt slide

* Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: 1 Corinthians 12:1-11 (NKJV)
"Now concerning spiritual gifts, brethren, I do not want you to be ignorant: 2 You know that you were Gentiles, carried away to these dumb idols, however you were led. 3 Therefore I make known to you that no one speaking by the Spirit of God calls Jesus accursed, and no one can say that Jesus is Lord except by the Holy Spirit. 4 There are diversities of gifts, but the same Spirit. 5 There are differences of ministries, but the same Lord. 6 And there are diversities of activities, but it is the same God who works all in all. 7 But the manifestation of the Spirit is given to each one for the profit of all: 8 for to one is given the <u>word of wisdom</u> through the

Spirit, to another the word of knowledge through the same Spirit, 9 to another faith by the same Spirit, to another gifts of healings by the same Spirit, 10 to another the working of miracles, to another prophecy, to another discerning of spirits, to another different kinds of tongues, to another the interpretation of tongues. 11 But one and the same Spirit works all these things, distributing to each one individually as He wills."

INTRO: The study we are about to embark upon will quite possibly be one of the most important teachings you have ever been a part of. If you can grasp the material that is about to be given to you, your life will never be the same.

The gifts of the Spirit were given to the first century church and were intended to continue as a feature of the New Testament church until the coming of our Lord. Some

have questioned whether the gifts were intended for the twenty first century church but I challenge anyone considering this notion to produce Scriptural evidence of their retraction.

Many people attempt to explain their underestimation of the importance of Spiritual gifts by saying *"we should be seeking the giver, not the gift"*. While it is true that we should seek the Giver (the Lord) more than His gifts, we must also remember that the Giver has something wonderful to give, or He would not be a giver. The Giver has at least nine perfect, precious, and powerful gifts to give to all of His children. Luke 11:13 (NKJV) ***"If you then, being evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask Him!"***

Some people question whether it is possible to talk about spiritual gifts without also including information on the fruit of the Spirit. Galatians 5:22-23 (NKJV) ***"But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, 23 gentleness, self-control. Against such there is no law."***

Spiritual gifts and the fruit of the Spirit are actually a part of each other. They should never be separated from one another.

Ideally, they should be connected one to another with love as the union binding them both tightly together. The nine gifts and the nine components of the fruit of the Spirit are a compliment to each other and one without the other is incomplete (Use illustration of an apple). The gifts without the fruit are like a car without gas: it is no good without that which it takes to cause it to run properly. In this case, love is that ingredient.

As we move through this study you will hear me refer to various components of the fruit of the Spirit as a necessary part of the exercising of the gifts. The exercising of gifts without the fruit is dangerous and can be deadly.

While some would emphasize the importance of the fruit of the Spirit, they also deemphasize the importance of the gifts of the Spirit. The gifts and the fruit are both vitally important, in fact Paul pens these words, 1 Corinthians 12:31 (KJV) ***"Covet earnestly the best gifts."*** Again he say's in 1 Corinthians 14:1(KJV) ***"Desire spiritual gifts."*** Finally in verse seven of our text he says ***"But the manifestation of the Spirit is given to each one for the profit of all."***

The gifts are extremely important to each individual believer, but they are crucial to the body of Christ. If I do not operate in the

gifts you get robbed, in the same way, if you refuse to operate in the gifts I get robbed.

What if your liver decided not to function, or take a year off? The rest of the body would be history in a matter of days! Every time you or I quench the Spirit, we cause irreparable harm to the remainder of the body! Every time we fail to exercise the gifts within their proper regulation, we also do irreparable damage. Knowing the proper regulation for the use of the gift is as important as receiving the gift.

Great damage can be sustained when a well-intentioned individual attempts to operate in a gift without doing so in a loving way or without properly following the regulation of the Gift. 1 Corinthians 14:32 (NKJV) ***"And the spirits of the prophets are subject to the prophets."***

A note of interest I would like to point out:
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Chapter 12 is all about Gifts…
- Chapter 13 is all about love…
- Chapter 14 is all about regulation of Gifts…

Gifts without love and regulations can often cause more harm than good. Gifts properly handled in a spirit of love and compassion is capable of taking a believer or body of believers to heights they have never even dreamed of!

God has provided these spiritual gifts and each gift has its unique place in the body of Christ as well as in the House of God.

One of the greatest misconceptions with regard to gifts centers around 1 Corinthians 12:31 (NKJV) ***"But earnestly desire the best gifts."*** Misinterpretation of this Scripture has created much controversy over

which gifts are the ***"Best Gifts."*** God would not have provided all nine of these gifts if some of them were unimportant or inconsequential. (In such a case there would have been eight, seven, six etc...)

It is not proper or possible to give a poll rating to these nine Spiritual Gifts. James 1:17 (KJV) states, ***"Every good and every perfect gift is from above, and cometh down from; the Father of lights, with whom is no variableness, neither shadow of turning."*** God is telling us that every gift He has to offer is "good" and "perfect". We should never downgrade or falsely rate a gift from divine hands as inferior or unimportant.

If we are not to rate them in order of importance, why are they listed in the Bible as they are and why does the Bible say to ***"earnestly desire the best gifts?"*** Consider this: When you list anything that has nine

components, all nine items cannot be listed first. Just because something is last is no indication that it is unimportant:

- Is Genesis more important than Revelation?
- Is the Old Testament more important than the New Testament?
- Is the first commandment more important than the last commandment?
- Is the Word of Wisdom more important than the Interpretation of Tongues?

1 Corinthians 12:31, says to "covet earnestly the best gifts." Notice that the word ***"gifts"*** is plural. This shows us there is more than one in the ***"best gift"*** category; in fact, they are all of equal importance.

Two chapters later it would appear that Paul contradicts himself and the idea of all gifts being equal in importance. 1 Corinthians 14:1 (NKJV) ***"Desire spiritual gifts, but rather that ye may prophesy."*** Here he

brings the sixth gift listed up to the top, into the ***"best gifts"*** class. Then he compares the sixth (Prophesy) with the eighth gift (divers kinds of tongues), and declares that the sixth is greater than the eighth, but with one exception, and that is 1 Corinthians 14:1-5 (KJV) ***"Follow after charity and desire spiritual gifts, but rather that ye may prophesy. For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue speaketh not unto men, but unto God; for no man understandeth him; howbeit in the Spirit he speaketh mysteries. But he that prophesieth speaketh unto men to edification, and exhortation, and comfort. He that speaketh in an unknown tongue edifieth himself; but he that prophesieth edifieth the church. I would that ye all spake with tongues, but rather that ye prophesied; for <u>greater is he that prophesieth than he that speaketh with tongues, except he interpret</u>, that the church may receive edifying."*** When the eighth and ninth are working together,

"divers kinds of tongues" and ***"interpretation of tongues"*** then it becomes co-equal with prophesy which has been raised to the ***"best gift"*** level.

If we take this at face value we would be extremely confused, but the clarifying factor is to understand that I Corinthians 12 is all about gifts and I Corinthians 14 is all about the regulation of gifts in public places. The reason prophesy is considered better than speaking in tongues in a public church service is because the person speaking in tongues is edifying himself, but the person who is prophesying is edifying the entire body.

I think it would be safe to conclude the best gift is the gift that is needed at the time: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- If one needs a word from the Lord a Word of wisdom is better than healing!

- If one needs a miracle, working of miracles is better than a word of knowledge!
- If one needs divine direction, prophesy is better than tongues!
- If one needs to be able to detect what spirit is in operation, discerning of spirits is better than faith!

All nine gifts are important and they are of equal importance.

It think it is safe to say that many shy away from spiritual gifts because of the misuse of gifts by some members of the body of Christ. The misuse of gifts has prejudiced a large part of the general church population against seeking them. The misuse of gifts is not the givers fault nor an inadequacy on the part of the gift. In fact, we are given direct orders with regard to the regulations concerning gifts. 1 Corinthians 14:40 (KJV)

"Let all things be done decently and in order."

The responsibility of correcting infractions against these wonderful gifts in public services is to be the charge of the pastor. This should always be done with love, tact, and wisdom. 2 Timothy 4:2 (KJV) ***"Preach the word; be instant in season, out of season; reprove, rebuke, exhort with all longsuffering and doctrine."***

Several reactions surface when leaders consider the responsibility of correcting infractions against proper operation of the gifts:

- They take the time to correct disorderly manifestations in a scriptural manner…
- They correct disorderly manifestations in an un-scriptural manner…
- They abandon and forbid the use of gifts altogether…

There are scriptural methods of correcting disorderly manifestations; however, forbidding the operation of gifts is not a biblical practice. 1 Corinthians 14:39 (NKJV) ***"Therefore, brethren, desire earnestly to prophesy, and do not forbid to speak with tongues."***

These nine Spiritual gifts are a vital part of our spiritual equipment for spreading the gospel around the world. They are also vital to the establishment of unity, spiritual health, and spiritual growth in the local congregation. Wherever these gifts are absent or lacking in a church, it often has many spiritual ills and the church is crippled by a lack of unity, slow spiritual growth, and displays of carnality.

Spiritual gifts are not toys to be played with, but tools to work with.

If every Christian would only realize how dependent we are on the Holy Spirit and then truly depend on Him, we would become:

- Healthy…
- Happy…
- Free…
- Victorious…
- Useful…
- Equipped…
- Strong…

A prominent question people ask regarding the gifts: are the gifts of the spirit meant for today? There are many who teach that the gifts of the spirit are not for today. The strongest arguments used to prove their point are that the manifestations of the Holy Spirit through the gifts were withdrawn at the close of the apostolic age.

We must ask: on what authority is this daring assertion made? This theological

assertion is certainly not made on the authority of the New Testament. There is not one line in the New Testament to indicate God intended to withdraw any of these gifts. In fact, quite the contrary is true. Romans 11:29 (NKJV) ***"For the gifts and the calling of God are irrevocable."*** Hebrews 13:8 (NKJV) ***"Jesus Christ is the same yesterday, today, and forever."***

There is one passage that seems to lend credence to the supposition that some of the gifts of the Spirit are not for today. It is the statement in 1 Corinthians 13:8 (NKJV) ***"Love never fails. But whether there are prophecies, they will fail; whether there are tongues, they will cease; whether there is knowledge, it will vanish away."*** Look at this passage in its proper context; 1 Corinthians 13:8-12 (NKJV) ***"Love never fails. But whether there are prophecies, they will fail; whether there are tongues, they will cease; whether there is***

knowledge, it will vanish away. 9 For we know in part and we prophesy in part. 10 But when that which is perfect has come, then that which is in part will be done away." When I was a child, I spoke as a child, I understood as a child, I thought as a child; but when I became a man, I put away childish things. 12 For now we see in a mirror, dimly, but then face to face. Now I know in part, but then I shall know just as I also am known."

Who are the gifts of the Spirit intended for? 1 Corinthians 12:11 (NKJV) ***"But one and the same Spirit works all these things, distributing to each one individually as He wills."***

The purpose of the gifts: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- During His earthly ministry Jesus operated in all the gifts. His plan for building His church was to empower us

through the dynamics of the Holy Spirit in Pentecostal fashion. The church Jesus intended to build was to have a supernatural witness. Its central point was to give testimony to a risen Christ who has ascended to the Father's right hand in Heaven, but still continuing to work with and through His people, thus perpetuating what He had only begun during His earthly ministry. Acts 1:1-8 (NKJV) ***"The former account I made, O Theophilus, of all that Jesus began both to do and teach, 2 until the day in which He was taken up, after He through the Holy Spirit had given commandments to the apostles whom He had chosen, 3 to whom He also presented Himself alive after His suffering by many infallible proofs, being seen by them during forty days and speaking of the things pertaining to the kingdom of God. 4 And being assembled together with them, He***

commanded them not to depart from Jerusalem, but to wait for the <u>Promise of the Father</u>, "which," He said, "you have heard from Me; 5 "for John truly baptized with water, but you shall be baptized with <u>the Holy Spirit</u> not many days from now." 6 Therefore, when they had come together, they asked Him, saying, "Lord, <u>will You at this time restore the kingdom to Israel</u>?" 7 And He said to them, "It is not for you to know times or seasons which the Father has put in His own authority. 8 "But <u>you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you</u>; and you shall be witnesses to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."

- Jesus left no doubt – the church was intended to have a <u>supernatural</u> order of ministry from its inception. John 14:12 (NKJV) ***"Most assuredly, I say to you, he who believes in Me, the works that I***

do he will do also; and greater works than these he will do, because I go to My Father." How is it possible that the church would do greater works than Jesus? It is possible to do greater works because the Spirit is working through more people. (Jesus did all miracles as a man anointed by the Holy Spirit) Acts 2:38-39 (NKJV) ***"Then Peter said to them, "Repent, and let every one of you be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins; and <u>you shall receive the gift of the Holy Spirit</u>. 39 "For the promise is to <u>you</u> and to <u>your children</u>, and to <u>all who are afar off</u>, as many as the Lord our <u>God will call</u>."*** I think it is significant that Jesus did not set aside a certain group of people to pour His Spirit out on, but He made this experience available to every believer.

- As a result of the Spirit's outpouring, spiritual gifts were given to provide a spiritual <u>capability</u> far greater than

natural abilities could ever offer. Every believer was intended to have a supernatural order of ministry. Gifts were not intended to operate in public church services exclusively but to empower individual believers.

- Gifts were intended to be a sign to unbelievers. Several times in Scripture we are reminded that a particular gift was used to convince an unbeliever of the authenticity of the power of God. 1 Corinthians 14:21-22 (NKJV) ***"In the law it is written: "With men of other tongues and other lips I will speak to this people; And yet, for all that, they will not hear Me," says the Lord. 22 Therefore tongues are for a sign, not to those who believe but to unbelievers; but prophesying is not for unbelievers but for those who believe."*** (Acts 13, 19, 28)

Endued with the gifts of the Spirit, the first century church was made strong to face the bitterest persecution, and endure the rigors of war, because she had a supernatural grip upon the unseen and eternal. The crafty devices of the enemy, when he would come as ***"an angel of light,"*** were also instantly detected.

The ultimate and full purpose of spiritual gifts: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- They are to bring men face to face with the reality of the Invisible God…
- To make the church realize that the Holy Spirit is ever present…
- All true ministry springs from Him who is the only source of life and power…
- To make the unbeliever equally conscious that God cannot be forgotten, and that sin dare not be trifled with…

The ideal, and the scriptural model, is a perfect blending of liberty for all to share in spiritual ministry, with recognition that some are divinely appointed to offices of leadership and divinely gifted for outstanding ministries as apostles, prophets, evangelists, pastors, and teachers.

When once again the church is enjoying her divine equipment, the utilization of every one of the Spirit's gifts, she will truly be; ***"looking forth as the morning, Fair as the moon, clear as the sun, Awesome as an army with banners?"*** Song of Solomon 6:10 (NKJV)

There are three classifications of these nine gifts of the Spirit; they can be categorized under three headings: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)
The Detection/Revelation Gifts:

1) The word of Wisdom…
2) The word of Knowledge…

3) Discerning of Spirits…

The Vocal Gifts:

1) Prophecy…
2) Tongues…
3) Interpretation of Tongues…

The Power Gifts:

1) Faith…
2) Miracles…
3) Gifts of Healings…

THE GIFTS OF THE SPIRIT
1 Corinthians 12:1-11

DETECTION/REVELATION GIFTS

THE WORD OF WISDOM - Vs. 8
According to our text, wisdom is a gift from God. This is a gift to the believer who asks for it and is willing to receive it. 1 Corinthians 12:8 (NKJV) ***"For to one is given the word of wisdom through the Spirit..."***

Wisdom is an extremely important ingredient in the life of the believer especially in these complicated days. Proverbs 4:7 (NKJV) ***"Wisdom is the principal thing; Therefore get wisdom. And in all your getting, get understanding."***

The gift of the Word of Wisdom is a wise or skillful way of making best use of knowledge and is the second listed gift of

the Spirit. It is the divine ability to assemble the components of the word of knowledge in a way that allows for the resolution of an otherwise impossible problem or obstacle.

The apostle James describes in eight points this heavenly wisdom in James 3:17, ***"But the wisdom that is from above is first..."*** (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Pure… No ulterior motives - Nathaniel ***"Behold an Israelite in whom there is no guile*** (deceit)***"***
- Peaceable… Seeks peace above all else - ***"Blessed are the peacemakers for they shall be called the children of God"***
- Gentle… ***"Wise as serpents, as harmless as doves"***
- Easy to be entreated… Don't have to walk around them on eggshells
- Full of mercy… More inclined to give the benefit of doubt than to judge

- Full of good fruit… ***"Love, joy, peace, longsuffering, gentleness, goodness, faith, meekness, self-control"***
- Without partiality… Does not play favorites
- Without hypocrisy… Does not pretend to be something they are not - Transparent - What you see is what you get - Real

Who is this gift for? All believers can operate in this gift. James 1:5 (NKJV) ***"If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask of God, who gives to all liberally and without reproach*** (Does not begrudge what He has given us)*, and it will be given to him."* Jesus promised this gift in Luke 21:15 (NKJV) ***"For I will give you a mouth and wisdom which all your adversaries will not be able to contradict or resist."*** This tells me that everyone who is born again and has a mouth is a candidate for the gift of wisdom.

Wouldn't it be nice if everyone in the church who has a mouth also had wisdom?

Can you imagine what kind of world this would be, or what kind of church this would be, if everyone operated in this one gift of the Spirit? I would be unemployed!

If you can imagine this, you have a pretty good idea of what the millennial reign of Christ will be like!

It is God's will for each of us to operate in this wonderful and necessary gift.

The operation of the gift of wisdom is the responsibility of the Spirit, not the believer! It is the believer's responsibility to ask for the gift at necessary intervals and to allow divine wisdom to supersede natural wisdom.

For the believer the crucial point is:
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Discerning when natural wisdom will be inadequate…
- Recognizing the need for a higher level of wisdom…
- Hearing accurately the instructions of divine wisdom…
- Walking in divine wisdom whether you understand all the dynamics of it or not…

The Gift of Wisdom is not:

- Some bright-idea of ours which flows from a superior degree of intelligence…
- Following the steps learned in a psychology class… This gift operates independent of our skills.
- It is not being clever or shrewd…

If this gift were reliant on our intelligence, skills, or natural ability sinners would probably be better at operating in this gift than Christians. According to Jesus ***"The children of this world are wiser in their***

generation than the children of light."
Jesus is basically saying that the world is normally more educated and in possession of a greater degree of knowledge than those in the household of faith.

Those of us who know Christ and are pursuing a higher dimension are regularly faced with situations that proceed beyond our understanding and require divine wisdom.

While it is true the children of this world normally have more resources than those who have trusted Christ, the wisdom of the world is not all that it has been billed to be!
James 3:15 *"This wisdom does not descend from above, but is…"* (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Earthly…
  Applauded and accepted by those who have no spiritual understanding - Found

to be inadequate by those who are spiritual.

- Sensual… Appeals to the senses - Taste, touch, sight, smell, and hearing.
- Demonic… Chooses the wrong path of correction – Airliner off course.

Examples of the gift of the word of wisdom:
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Solomon was blessed with this spiritual ability… Two women who were arguing over the parenthood of a newborn – Solomon said ***"Cut the baby in half"*** – Thus establishing the true identity of the mother.
- Jesus operated in this area of giftedness… At 12 He was able to debate the rulers of the synagogue.
- Peter operated in this gift… Sent to the house of Cornelius - He did not come up with this on his own.
- All of the Apostles operated in this gift from time to time…

- The first century church was accustomed to allowing this gift to operate… The selection of Deacons.

PRACTICAL APPLICATION:

If this gift is available to all of us how do we reach the point that we allow this gift to operate through us? (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Walk as closely to God as possible…
- Listen closely enough to the spirit to detect when rational direction is not right direction… (He that hath an ear let him hear what the Spirit is saying)
- When feelings of discomfort arise ask the Spirit for divine wisdom…
- Follow the voice of the Spirit no matter how opposite it may be when compared to natural wisdom… (God often speaks to us through impressions)
- Exercise faith at all times… Work at overcoming feelings of fear. (Young man at Palestine - Migranes)

THE GIFTS OF THE SPIRIT
(1 Corinthians 12: 1-11)

THE WORD OF KNOWLEDGE – Vs. 8

I want to call your attention to verse eight of our text. I Corinthians 12:8 (NKJV) ***"To another the word of knowledge by the same Spirit."***

In last week's study we learned the word of wisdom can be most accurately understood as receiving divine direction concerning a particular situation. The word of knowledge is the divine ability to know facts that are not otherwise apparent. Even though the word of knowledge and the word of wisdom are two distinct gifts, they often operate in tandem.

When an individual is going through a particularly perplexing situation, what could be better than for God to reveal certain facts

that would be impossible to otherwise know and then reveal the pattern for the solution?

This can happen in: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The first person… Receive it yourself.
- The second person… Another person speaks a word of knowledge over you.
- The third person… God speaks a word of knowledge to someone who passes the information along to you through another person.

If it is the intention of the Heavenly Father to reveal the solution to difficult situations through the word of wisdom, what importance does the word of knowledge play in such a scenario? (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Births faith in the heart of the person who is going through the difficulty…
- Confirmation that God is walking through the difficulty with them…

- Increases the faith level to where the individual can receive the word of wisdom…
- Increases the faith level to a point where the individual is willing to follow the instructions of the word of wisdom…
- Increases the faith of the individual whom the gift is operating through…

Though we live in the information age and knowledge is increasing at a mind boggling pace, the knowledge of the world is terribly inferior to the knowledge of God. The knowledge of this world does not qualify an individual to operate in the gift of the word of knowledge. No amount of studying and education can bring about this wonderful gift!

The word of knowledge operates through divine revelation; it is not what we suspect; it is not what we have observed; it is not what we have conjured up through analyzing

another human being; it is not the gift of suspicion; it is facts revealed through the Spirit.

The word of knowledge can and should be a powerful tool in the hands of the modern day church. This gift is closely related to the gift of discerning of spirits.

This 12th chapter of I Corinthians opened with these words, 1 Corinthians 12:1 (NKJV) ***"Now concerning spiritual gifts, brethren, I do not want you to be ignorant."*** This expression is often repeated in the New Testament: Romans 11:25; I Corinthians 10:1; 2 Corinthians 1:8; 1Thessalonians 4:13; 2 Peter 3:8.

Ignorance in any arena can be extremely frustrating for both the participant and the by-stander; it can also be very damaging.

Someone said, *"What you don't know won't hurt you."* Who are we kidding? What you don't know can kill you!

- When you are crossing a railroad track what if you don't know a train is coming?
- What if a cancer cell gets loose in your body and you are not aware of it?
- What if a close friend has a highly communicable disease and you know nothing of it?

I want to use a very common modern day occurrence to demonstrate a very important spiritual lesson – driving. Most of us take it for granted and do it so often that we rarely give it a second thought. Driving is a privilege not an entitlement.

There are safe drivers and there are drivers who are a menace to everyone else on the

roadway. (I don't know how all of them knew to relocate to Houston!)

Despite the fact they are not operating out of malice or animosity, a person who attempts to drive an automobile without the necessary knowledge or skills can be a very real danger to all other drivers and passengers. A friendly unskilled driver can kill you just as quick as an angry unskilled driver!

Before you are issued a driver's license, you must demonstrate a certain level of knowledge and skill.

You must pass a written test that includes a general knowledge of the road, its rules, and signs.

You must pass a driving test in which you must demonstrate the skills necessary for the safe operation of a motor vehicle.

If you cannot satisfactorily demonstrate knowledge that exceeds the minimum standard set by the state, you cannot legally operate an automobile.

Any unauthorized operation of such a vehicle is subject to the penalties of the law of the land.

The requirements of operation for a motor vehicle are designed to protect the operator as well as every other person who frequents the roadways.

If you have a license but choose to go outside the boundaries of operating a motor vehicle in a safe manner, you are in danger of the penalty of the law.

Paul is saying to the Corinthian Christians here that God desires to give each of His children a group of spiritual gifts that will enhance our trip to heaven. He is also saying

that if you are to receive these gifts you should commit yourself to acquiring the skill and knowledge necessary for the proper operation of the gift. Unauthorized or irresponsible use of the gifts will be penalized.

The polar opposite of knowledge is ignorance. In this passage of Scripture, we are being told to become knowledgeable of the proper operation of the gifts, including the gift of knowledge.

God does not want his children to operate out of ignorance. If we operate in ignorance, we have, by an act of our own will, chosen to do so. We have been given the five-fold ministry gifts: apostles, prophets, evangelists, pastors, and teachers. These gifts have been placed in the body for the ***"...perfecting of the saints, and the work of the ministry."*** Jeremiah 3:15 (NKJV) ***"And I will give you shepherds according to My***

heart, who will feed you with knowledge and understanding."

The final outcome is often the same whether a person is ignorant, vicious, or over zealous.

We will be held responsible for the damage we inflict on others and ourselves. I don't want to strike fear in your heart regarding the framework and operation of the gifts of the Spirit, but improper operation of gifts can be more damaging than helpful.

When the church is ignorant of the scriptures, uninformed or misinformed on vital doctrines, much harm is done to the cause of Christ. 2 Peter 3:16 (NKJV) ***"... some things are hard to understand, which untaught and unstable people twist to their own destruction, as they do also the rest of the Scriptures."*** Hosea 4:6 (NKJV) ***"My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge.***

Because you have rejected knowledge, I also will reject you from being priest for Me; Because you have forgotten the law of your God, I also will forget your children."

Several illustrations in scripture reveal the word of knowledge in operation: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- 2 Kings 6:9-12 - God revealed the military plans and secret maneuvers of the Syrians to the prophet Elisha.
- John 1:47-51 - Jesus exercised this gift when he engaged in a conversation with Nathaniel. ***"Jesus saw Nathanael coming to him, and saith of him, Behold an Israelite indeed, in whom is no guile! [48]Nathanael saith unto him, Whence knowest thou me? Jesus answered and said unto him, Before that Philip called thee, when thou wast under the fig tree, I saw thee. [49] Nathanael answered and saith unto him, Rabbi, thou art the Son of God;***

thou art the King of Israel. [50]Jesus answered and said unto him, Because I said unto thee, I saw thee under the fig tree, believest thou? thou shalt see greater things than these. [51]And he saith unto him, Verily, verily, I say unto you, Hereafter ye shall see heaven open, and the angels of God ascending and descending upon the Son of man."

- Acts 5:1-10 - God revealed to the apostle Peter the scheming of Ananias & Sapphira.
- Acts 9:10-18 - God revealed to Ananias (not the same person that is mentioned in Acts 5) the whereabouts of one called Saul of Tarsus. He also revealed what Saul was doing, and what God had in mind for this new convert – immediately, and in the future.
- Acts 27 - God revealed to Paul that the storm on the sea would not result in the loss of life as long as everyone stayed in

the ship. This is the word of knowledge accompanied with the word of wisdom.

PRACTICAL APPLICATION:
How are we to allow this gift to operate through us? We must first develop a listening ear. There is no substitute for sensitivity to the Spirit. The seven churches of revelation were no doubt set in different eras and various cultures... some were difficult; some were wicked; some were doctrinally unsound; but one statement was made to all of them: ***"He that hath an ear let him hear what the Spirit is saying to the church."***

Be aware of how God speaks. God speaks through His Word; He speaks through people; He speaks through impressions. We should do the following: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Pray to be sensitive enough to hear His voice…

- Obey - speaking what He has given us…
- As with any other gift or ability we will become more comfortable and confident with experience…

THE GIFTS OF THE SPIRIT
(1 Corinthians 12:1-11)

DISCERNING OF SPIRITS - Vs. 10
In order to group the gifts by threes – revelation gifts; power gifts; utterance gifts; we are going to take the gift of discerning of spirits out of the chronological order in which it is listed in I Corinthians 12. The revelation gifts are: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Word of wisdom…
- Word of knowledge…
- Discerning of spirits…

The study of discerning of spirits will conclude our study of revelation gifts.

Discerning of spirits is the seventh gift listed and can be found in 1 Corinthians 12:10 (NKJV) "***to another the working of miracles, to another prophecy, to another discerning of spirits, to another different***

kinds of tongues, to another the interpretation of tongues."

This gift must not be confused with a critical spirit, analytical ability, telepathy, mind reading, or suspicion. It is in no way a psychic ability; it is, in the truest sense of the word, a gift that allows our spirit to bear witness with another person's spirit. In the event our spirit does not bear witness, this gift allows us to know what spirit is in operation.

As is the case with all other gifts, this gift is not given to make us look super-spiritual, but allows for a marked advantage in our battle against the enemy by being able to detect the specific spirit behind each attack, allowing the believer to target a spirit rather than a personality.

This generation has become so enamored with the supernatural and having someone to

foresee the future, that many so called Christians consult psychics, read their horoscopes, play with Ouija boards, and constantly seek out individuals to receive a word about their future. This pursuit includes information about employment, relationships, health issues, financial obligations, investment strategies, and anything regarding the future.

There is certainly nothing wrong with allowing a person of God to speak into our lives, but we better make sure about the character and the spiritual connectedness of the person who is doing the speaking. This is why we feel it is so important to train and screen altar workers.

It is certainly not necessary for the person doing the speaking to be perfect, none of us are, but the source of the word must be from the throne of God. If it is not, it will do far more damage than good.

If a false word is spoken, it can alter the course of one’s life in a very negative way and quite possibly circumvent the destiny God has in mind for the individual. For instance: If God were calling a person to be a banker and someone prophesied to them that God wanted them to be a pastor, if that person were not a discerning person, they might go in a wrong direction and live a frustrated life. (Pastor who hated being a pastor)

In a case like this, an individual’s whole life could be frustrated because they pursued a destiny they weren't called to. In such a case both the individual who received an erroneous word as well as everyone they minister to suffer from the mistake.

A person whose source is not from above could attempt to speak a curse on what God intended to bless.

A good rule of thumb for the revelation gifts is that God will never surprise us with a new word; the word He gives will only confirm what He has already been speaking to us.

Discerning of spirits allows the believer to be able to detect what kind of spirit or spirits are in operation in any given situation. (Security at the airport)

This gift is intended to go much further than just simple detection of a spirit. It is intended to: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Bring the person to a place of repentance…
- Correct wrong actions…
- Provide a new course of action…

The word "discerning" (Greek, diakrisis) means to judge or be able to sort through the evidence, eventually reaching a correct

understanding of the facts. The intention of this gift is to be able to look beyond the outward to see what is not readily apparent in the invisible world of the spiritual, then forming a judgment based on that insight.

This gift is important to every Christian but it is absolutely essential to those who serve in responsible positions of church government.

It cannot be stated too emphatically that this spiritual gift operates only through born again believers. 1 Corinthians 2:14-15 (NKJV) ***"But the natural man does not receive the things of the Spirit of God, for they are foolishness to him; nor can he know them, because they are spiritually discerned. 15 But he who is spiritual judges all things, yet he himself is rightly judged by no one."***

This gift is intended for two reasons:
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Detection of demonic spirits operating through unbelievers… One of the unique features of the ministry of Jesus was casting demons out of those who were bound. Legion - Mt. 8 - The dumb man - Mt. 9 - The dumb and blind man - Mt.12 - Little Canaanite girl vexed with a devil whose mother sought Jesus out - Mt. 15 - A young man who is described as a lunatic whose father sought Jesus out (The boy would cast himself in the fire or in the water) - Mt. 17 - Man in the synagogue with an unclean spirit - Mk. 1 - Mary Magdalene delivered of seven devils - Luke - 8 Casting out evil spirits was also a feature of the apostolic ministry as well as that of the New Testament church - Acts 16:16-18 (NKJV) ***"Now it happened, as we went to prayer, that a certain slave girl possessed with a spirit of divination met***

us, who brought her masters much profit by fortune-telling.17 This girl followed Paul and us, and cried out, saying, "<u>These men are the servants of the Most High God</u>, who proclaim to us the way of salvation."18 And <u>this she did for many days</u>. But Paul, greatly annoyed, turned and said to the spirit, "<u>I command you in the name of Jesus Christ to come out of her</u>." <u>And he came out that very hour</u>." Casting out demons is supposed to be a feature of the modern day church - Mark 16:15-20 (NKJV) ***"And He said to them, "Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature.16 "He who believes and is baptized will be saved; but he who does not believe will be condemned.17 "And these signs will follow those who believe: In My name <u>they will cast out demons</u>; they will speak with new tongues;18 "they will take up serpents; and if they drink***

anything deadly, it will by no means hurt them; they will lay hands on the sick, and they will recover." 19 So then, after the Lord had spoken to them, He was received up into heaven, and sat down at the right hand of God.20 And they went out and preached everywhere, the Lord working with them and confirming the word through the accompanying signs. Amen." (Story of young lady in Malvern on a Sunday morning)

- Detection of demonic spirits attempting to influence Christians… Let me explain right up front that I do not believe a Christian can be demon possessed, but I do believe Christians can be influenced by demonic spirits. When demonic spirits operate through sinners we call that possession; when they influence Christians we call that oppression. (Explain the difference between possession and oppression - Afghanistan

and the Taliban - The difference in dealing with the two - In possession you cast the devil out - In oppression you cast the spirit down) (My first experience with this was dealing with a young lady who was being vexed by a spirit of infirmity) You don't have to believe me, all you have to do is look at the ministry of Jesus and the Apostles. (1) When James and John saw the rejection of the ministry of Jesus by the people of a Samaritan village, they were so angry they attempted to call down fire from heaven to consume the people. Notice how Jesus responded to their actions. Luke 9:55-56 (NKJV) ***"But He turned and rebuked them, and said, "<u>You do not know what manner of spirit you are of</u>.56 "For the Son of Man did not come to destroy men's lives but to save them."*** (2) In Matthew 16 Jesus told His disciples of all the things He was about to face and he told

them that in Jerusalem He would suffer reproach, humiliation, and eventually death. Peter couldn't take it any longer and spoke up, decrying the words Jesus was speaking. Matthew 16:22 (NKJV) ***"Then Peter took Him aside and began to rebuke Him, saying, "Far be it from You, <u>Lord; this shall not happen to You</u>!"*** Peter was no doubt trying to do a good thing; our motives can be good but our influence from the wrong source! Notice how Jesus responded to Peter. Matthew 16:23 (NKJV) ***"But He turned and said to Peter, "<u>Get behind Me, Satan</u>! You are an offense to Me, for you are not mindful of the things of God, but the things of men."*** (3) Philip, Peter, and John were at Samaria and Simon the sorcerer received Christ! Acts 8:13 (NKJV) ***"Then <u>Simon himself also believed</u>; and when <u>he was baptized</u> he continued with Philip, and was amazed, seeing the miracles and***

signs which were done." In verse 18 he offered the Apostles money for the gift of laying hands on people to receive the gift of the Holy Ghost. Acts 8:20-24 (NKJV) ***"But Peter said to him, "Your money perish with you, because you thought that the gift of God could be purchased with money!21 "You have neither part nor portion in this matter, for <u>your heart is not right in the sight of God</u>.22 "<u>Repent</u> therefore of this your wickedness, and pray God if perhaps the thought of your heart may be forgiven you.23 "For I see that <u>you are poisoned by bitterness and bound by iniquity</u>."24 Then Simon answered and said, "Pray to the Lord for me, that none of the things which you have spoken may come upon me."***

The following is a list of 16 strongholds and the scripture references to back them up. These strongholds can affect an unbeliever

as well as the life and spiritual walk of a believer: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Stronghold of anti-Christ - 1 John 4:3
- Stronghold of bondage - Romans 8:15
- Deaf and dumb stronghold - Mark 9:17-29
- Stronghold of death - Revelation 20:13-14
- Stronghold of divination - Acts 16:16-18
- Stronghold of error - 1 John 4:6
- Familiar stronghold - Leviticus 19:31
- Stronghold of fear - 2 Timothy 1:7
- Stronghold of haughtiness (pride) - Proverbs 16:18
- Stronghold of heaviness - Isaiah 61:3
- Stronghold of infirmity - Luke 13:11-13
- Stronghold of jealousy - Numbers 5:14
- Stronghold of lying - 2 Chronicles 18:22
- Stronghold of perversion - Isaiah 19:14
- Stronghold of seduction - 1 Timothy 4:1
- Stronghold of whoredom - Hosea 4:12

The very name of this gift reveals its true character and scope. It is discerning of spirits, not the actions of individuals. This gift reveals the plans, purposes, activities, and manifestations of both the Spirit of God and spirits that are not of God.

This gift reveals the inward activity of demonic forces that would normally escape the recognition of most Christians. (My own experience with anger - story of young lady who saw demons lined up on her curb)

It is extremely important to have this gift operating in your life because the Word reveals that Satan and his ministers would come as wolves dressed in sheep's clothing. 2 Corinthians 11:13-15 (NKJV) ***"For such are false apostles, deceitful workers, <u>transforming themselves</u> into apostles of Christ.14 And no wonder! For <u>Satan himself transforms himself into an angel of light</u>.15 Therefore it is no great thing if <u>his</u>***

ministers also transform themselves into ministers of righteousness, whose end will be according to their works."

This gift of discerning of Spirits will rip off the Devil's mask of deception and expose his devices. Satan hates the manifestation of the gifts of the Spirit; he especially hates the gift of discerning of spirits because it carries with it the ability to thwart his plans even before they have the opportunity to succeed.

All previously mentioned spirits can probably be categorized into three categories: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Holy Spirit…
- Evil spirits…
- Human spirits…

What can be done about these three spirits?

If the Holy Spirit is in operation we must do one of two things: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Get out of the way, allowing Him to do His work…
- Obey His instructions…

If an evil spirit is in operation we must do one of three things: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Discern what spirit is in operation…
- Pray very specifically against the spirit commanding it to cease its activities…
- Cast it out or cast it down depending on whether it is possession or oppression…

If a human spirit is in operation we must do the following things: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Pray for grace to show the kindness of Christ…
- Never allow our spirit to become frustrated…

- Pray for the individual to adopt the mind of Christ…

The mere existence of such a gift as discerning of spirits reveals the real existence of evil and deceiving spirits manifesting themselves through human beings.

As more of God's Spirit is in operation in us, there will be a keener awareness as to the operation of satanic power.

The gift of discerning of spirits, just like the other eight spiritual gifts is not a product of reasoning, or of our natural abilities. God will not entrust this or any of His gifts to serve as a means of entertainment to satisfy the curiosity of carnal Christians. These gifts are not given for personal gain or to satisfy some selfish ambition.

God supplies His gifts to accelerate the ministry of imperfect but authentic Christians, who are attempting to minister in an imperfect world.

The preaching of the gospel should go forth with such anointing as to make un-Christ-like spirits uncomfortable. When the gifts of the spirit are in full operation in the church some people will grow increasingly uncomfortable because they sense they are losing control or they feel they are in danger of being exposed. Demonic spirits will never be able to remain undetected in a spiritual church. Satan wants to covertly operate evil spirits in God's house to do several things:

- To hinder church services…
- To sow discord within the body…
- To stir up confusion…
- To contaminate the pattern of the Christian walk… (Making good look evil and evil look good)

PRACTICAL APPLICATION:
There may be individuals in this audience who have identified portions of their behavior with the manifestations of a spirit that is not like Christ, and as a result you may be concerned about your standing and relationship with God. Because you can identify yourself with a un-Christ-like manifestation does not mean you are demon possessed. It could be that one or more of these spirits are influencing, harassing, or manipulating you.

I have good news! You can experience freedom in Jesus!

Once you have been made aware of the influence, harassment, and manipulation of the enemy, to persist in those behavior patterns is the equivalent of signaling to that particular spirit to invade your life with all kinds of other vexing problems.

If you willingly open the door, the tormenting spirits of darkness will attack you without mercy, causing you to be weak, discouraged, and defeated.

To allow this gift of discerning of spirits to operate freely in your life, the following things will be absolutely necessary: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Have a personal relationship with Jesus…
- Be baptized in the Holy Spirit…
- Be a person of prayer…
- Be a person of the Word…
- Be aware of the spirit world…
- Listen to the voice of the Holy Spirit…
- Attack the spirit not the person…

POWER GIFTS

THE GIFTS OF THE SPIRIT
1 Corinthians 12:1-11

THE GIFT OF FAITH - Vs. 9
The first three gifts in this series, we classified as revelation gifts: the word of wisdom, the word of knowledge, and discerning of spirits. The next three gifts: faith, healing and miracles, I would like to classify as power gifts.

First of all, we are going to study the gift of faith. In postmodern times, faith is a frequently preached but rarely practiced theological truth.

Contrary to popular belief within the church one need not be saved to possess and exercise faith:

- Every time a person steps on an airplane, they are exercising faith in the pilot and the equipment!
- Every time a person steps into an elevator, they are exercising faith in the manufacturer and the machine!
- Every time a person gets into their automobile, they are exercising faith in their own ability and the ability of the vehicle!

It is not necessary to be saved to exercise this kind of faith. Romans 12:3 (KJV) ***"For I say, through the grace given unto me, to every man that is among you, not to think of himself more highly than he ought to think; but to think soberly, according as God hath dealt to every man the measure of faith."*** (Thomas Jefferson - The Declaration of Independence - *"We hold these truths to be self evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable rights, that*

among these are life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness." Thomas Jefferson was no doubt a good man and I agree with the theory that in America every person should have an equal chance at success, but all of us are obviously not created equal:

- The DNA of every individual is unique to that person…
- Every fingerprint is original and cannot be duplicated…
- The iris in the eye is different with every person…
- Some are stronger and some are weaker…
- Some are smarter and some are not as smart…
- Some are pretty and some are not as pretty…

While the abilities and intellect of each person is very different, it is true that initially all men have been given exactly the same measure of faith. If it is true that each

person has been given the same faith as all other people - when and where did we receive this faith and how did this occur to begin with? In this lesson we are going to study three venues from which we receive faith: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Faith is imparted…
- Faith is given as a fruit of the spirit…
- Faith is given as a gift…

If we are to please God and live up to our potential, fulfilling our reason for being on this earth, we must receive faith from all three venues. Hebrews 11:6 (NKJV) ***"But without faith it is impossible to please him: for he that cometh to God must believe that He is, and that He is a rewarder of them that diligently seek Him."***

IMPARTED FAITH

The impartation of this gift occurs at the moment of conception. To prove my point,

allow me to take you on a practical and scriptural journey. Why are you alive?

You are alive because God empowered your mother and father to reproduce.

Reproduction in and of itself is a mind-boggling miracle, but allow me to simplify the matter by saying God breathed into your nostrils the breath of life. Genesis 2:7 (KJV) ***"And the LORD God formed man of the dust of the ground, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and man became a living soul."*** The word ***"breathed"*** as it is used here comes from the Hebrew word *"naphach"* (naw-fakh') and means to puff, to inflate to blow hard. The word ***"breath"*** comes from the Hebrew word *"neshamah"* (nesh-aw-maw') and means a puff; a violent breath; divine intellect or inspiration. We could paraphrase this Scripture by saying, ***"And the Lord God formed man from the dust of the ground, and blew into his***

nostrils, divine intellect; and man became a living person."

If this is true, abortion does more than stop a beating heart; it kills divine intellect. (Too bad for the abortionists that it is not possible to make it retroactive) A watermelon seed has resident within it: the vine, the leaves, the rind, the meat, and the power to reproduce itself. To take a life from the womb kills everything God intended for that individual.

The reason we were not stillborn is because God, with His breath, blew divine intellect into our nostrils and commanded us to live! Listen to this, 2 Timothy 3:16-17 (NKJV) ***"All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: 17 That the man of God may be perfect, thoroughly furnished unto all good works."*** The life and breath that we

have points up the fact that behind all the pretense and façade, there is within our genetic makeup, faith that was imparted to us from Father God! An atheist who chooses to believe there is no God points up the fact there really is a God.

Please understand that the intellect does not produce faith, but gives man the capacity to receive, possess, exercise and cultivate faith.

We are commanded to develop our intellect to its maximum potential so we can offer it to God for His use. 2 Timothy 2:15 (KJV) ***"Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth."***

On the other hand, no matter how intelligent we become in the natural, how high or low our IQ may be, when oxygen ceases to flow to our brains we lose all ability to think and function. Why does this happen? Because

Satan, through the fall (not just Adam's sin - all of our sin) perverted the seed of faith placed in us at conception. Because of the seed of sin, imparted faith is temporary and leaves much to be desired.

THE FRUIT OF FAITH

Faith is not only imparted at conception, it is planted as a seed at conversion. In Luke 8 Jesus gives the parable of the sower and the seed. In verse 11 He explains the parable, ***"Now the parable is this: The seed is the word of God."***

Listen to this: John 1:10-14 (NKJV) ***"He was in the world, and the world was made by him, and the world knew him not. 11 He came unto his own, and his own received him not. 12 But as many as received him, to them gave he power to become the sons of God, even to them that believe on his name: 13 Which were born, not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, nor of the will***

of man, but <u>of God</u>. 14 And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth."

If I interpret the scripture correctly the miracle that happens at conversion simply put is this: The seed of God is planted within us. What happens when we plant a seed?

- It sprouts and grows…
- It withers and dies…
- It comes to maturity…

(My experience as a teenager in a peach orchard)

Galatians 5:22-25 (NKJV) ***"But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, gentleness, goodness, <u>faith</u>, 23 Meekness, temperance: against such there is no law. 24 And they that are Christ's have crucified the flesh with the affections and***

lusts. 25 If we live in the Spirit, let us also walk in the Spirit."

At conversion the seed of the fruit of the spirit is deposited in our life. Whether or not that fruit ever comes to maturity depends totally on how the individual responds to it and cultivates it. Faith is a component of the fruit of the spirit.

If faith as a fruit is deposited in our lives at conversion, then it is up to us to tend that seed, develop, cultivate, and bring it to full maturity. Once the seed of faith has been planted, the responsibility for its development resides with the recipient. How are we to faithfully execute this very important responsibility? Romans 10:17 (NKJV) ***"So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God."***

Once the seed of faith has been planted at conversion, we begin the process of

developing faith into mature fruit through the study, memorization, and practice of the Word of God.

The development of fruit is a day-by-day maturation process. This is the very reason we believe in progressive sanctification.

Always remember: this can only be done while the growing season lasts. Even so, we are given a season for developing, maturing, and utilizing the gift of God in our life.

Every day counts! We must view today as a gift and maximize each day through developing and utilizing every facet of His generosity, especially the seed of faith that has been deposited within us.

To sit around and wait for God to do something through us is the equivalent of our children refusing to utilize the gifts we have given them unless and until we agree to

unwrap and press them into service on their behalf!

James 2:17-18 (NKJV) ***"Even so faith, if it hath not works, is dead, being alone. 18 Yea, a man may say, Thou hast faith, and I have works: shew me thy faith without thy works, and I will shew thee my faith by my works."***

James 2:26 (NKJV) ***"For as the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without works is dead also."***

We are saved by faith, not by works. But once we are converted, we continually receive faith-lifts by mixing faith with works.

Fruit does not grow unless there is some variation in the temperature, an adequate amount of sunshine, substantial periods of

darkness, and ample rainfall that is often accompanied by storms.

The fruit never makes demands on the husbandman, but the work of the husbandman always determines the marketability of the full-grown fruit. (Pruning - fertilizing - applying pesticides - breaking up the ground - etc...)

Imparted faith and intellect was perfect at the point of impartation, but became fragmented by the fall. The first thing sin did was to bring the knowledge of a wrong done. Genesis 3:1-6 (NKJV) ***"Now the serpent was more cunning than any beast of the field which the LORD God had made. And he said to the woman, "Has God indeed said, 'You shall not eat of every tree of the garden'?"2 And the woman said to the serpent, "We may eat the fruit of the trees of the garden;3 "but of the fruit of the tree which is in the midst of the garden,***

God has said, 'You shall not eat it, nor shall you touch it, lest you die.' "4 Then the serpent said to the woman, "<u>You will not surely die</u>.5 "For God knows that in the day you eat of it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God, knowing good and evil."6 So when the woman saw that the tree was good for food, that it was pleasant to the eyes, and a tree desirable to make one wise, she took of its fruit and ate. She also gave to her husband with her, and he ate."

The second thing sin did was to bring about fear. Genesis 3:9-10 (NKJV) ***"Then the LORD God called to Adam and said to him, "Where are you?"10 So he said, "I heard Your voice in the garden, and <u>I was afraid</u> because I was naked; and I hid myself."***

According to these passages of scripture, sin directly assaults our intellect and our faith.

When we give in to sin, we allow our intellect and our faith to become fragmented. 1 Corinthians 13:8-13 (NKJV) ***"Love never fails. But whether there are prophecies, they will fail; whether there are tongues, they will cease; whether there is knowledge, it will vanish away.9 For we know in <u>part</u> and we prophesy in <u>part</u>.10 But when that which is perfect has come, then that which is in <u>part</u> will be done away.11 When I was a child, I spoke as a child, I understood as a child, I thought as a child; but when I became a man, I put away childish things.12 For now we see in a mirror, dimly, but then face to face. Now I know in <u>part</u>, but then I shall know just as I also am known.13 And now abide faith, hope, love, these three; but the greatest of these is love."*** The word ***"part"*** here means fragment.

The fruit of faith is a process of putting the pieces back together. The efforts of the child

of God and the work of the Holy Spirit are to pick up the pieces of the fragmentation and build our intellect and faith until we are made into the image of His dear Son. When we are made into the image of God, we do His work and produce His fruit.

If the fruit inspector were to walk into this house tonight and demand an evaluation of the fruit of our life, especially that which our faith has produced, I wonder what his report would look like tomorrow? (Experience grading peaches in the peach orchard)

Do we look forward to the day of reckoning or do we dread the confrontation? If you do not look forward to such an encounter with excitement and anticipation, when will you change the activity of your life that is producing such substandard results? Will you make the necessary changes today, tomorrow? If not, when?

WARNING: The fruit inspector is in the house and the day of reckoning is at hand!

THE GIFT OF FAITH

God wants us as His children to have faith, so much so that He has provided it for us through many sources and channels. From Paradise to Patmos, faith is the common denominator of Christ honoring, God pleasing people. Hebrews 11:*6* (NKJV) ***"But without faith it is impossible to please him: for he that cometh to God must believe that he is (exists), and that he is a rewarder of them that diligently seek him."*** Faith is the only ingredient mentioned in both the Galatian list of fruit and the Corinthian list of gifts.

Just as the fruit of faith is different from imparted (natural) faith, the gift of faith is different from the fruit of faith. The gift of faith can only be received following the experience of the Baptism in the Holy Spirit.

The fruit of faith is what God does through us; walking out His Word, learning to stand on His promises; the gift of faith is what God does for us.

Through the fruit of faith we have discovered that God is able to bring us through the trials and tests that the enemy places in our pathway. The gift of faith goes far beyond just believing God is able, to the point of speaking things into existence that seem totally irrational to the human mind. Faith receives things by the Spirit and ***"calls those things that are not as though they were."*** This kind of faith moves you into a place where God honors your word as his own and miraculously brings it to pass. Mark 11:23-24 (NKJV) ***"For assuredly, I say to you, whoever says to this mountain, 'Be removed and be cast into the sea,' and does not doubt in his heart, but believes that those things he says will be done, he***

will have whatever he says.24 "Therefore I say to you, whatever things you ask when you pray, believe that you receive them, and you will have them." Job 22:27-28 (NKJV) ***"You will make your prayer to Him, He will hear you, And you will pay your vows. 28 You will also declare a thing, And it will be established for you; So light will shine on your ways."***

Let us look at such an occurrence in the Old Testament and a couple of instances in the New Testament.

Ezekiel 37:1-10 (NKJV) ***"The hand of the LORD came upon me and brought me out in the Spirit of the LORD, and set me down in the midst of the valley; and it was full of bones.2 Then He caused me to pass by them all around, and behold, there were very many in the open valley; and indeed they were very dry.3 And He said to me, "Son of man, can these bones live?" So I***

answered, "<u>O Lord GOD, You know</u>."4 Again He said to me, "<u>Prophesy to these bones</u>, and say to them, 'O dry bones, hear the word of the LORD! 5 'Thus says the Lord GOD to these bones: "Surely I will cause breath to enter into you, and you shall live.6 "I will put sinews on you and bring flesh upon you, cover you with skin and put breath in you; and you shall live. Then you shall know that I am the LORD.7 <u>So I prophesied as I was commanded</u>; and as I prophesied, there was a noise, and suddenly a rattling; and the bones came together, bone to bone.8 Indeed, as I looked, the sinews and the flesh came upon them, and the skin covered them over; but there was no breath in them.9 Also He said to me, "<u>Prophesy to the breath</u>, prophesy, son of man, and say to the breath, 'Thus says the Lord GOD: "Come from the four winds, O breath, and breathe on these slain, that they may live.10 <u>So I prophesied as He commanded me</u>, and breath came

into them, and they lived, and stood upon their feet, an exceedingly great army."

Acts 12:1-11 (NKJV) ***"Now about that time Herod the king stretched out his hand to harass some from the church.2 Then he killed James the brother of John with the sword.3 And because he saw that it pleased the Jews, <u>he proceeded further to seize Peter also</u>. Now it was during the Days of Unleavened Bread.4 <u>So when he had arrested him, he put him in prison</u>, and delivered him to four squads of soldiers to keep him, intending to bring him before the people after Passover. 5 Peter was therefore kept in prison, but constant <u>prayer was offered to God for him by the church</u>.6 And when Herod was about to bring him out, that night <u>Peter was sleeping, bound with two chains between two soldiers; and the guards before the door were keeping the prison</u>.7 Now behold, an angel of the Lord stood by him,***

and a light shone in the prison; and he struck Peter on the side and raised him up, saying, "Arise quickly!" And his chains fell off his hands.8 Then the angel said to him, "Gird yourself and tie on your sandals"; and so he did. And he said to him, "Put on your garment and follow me."9 So he went out and followed him, and did not know that what was done by the angel was real, but thought he was seeing a vision.10 When they were past the first and the second guard posts, they came to the iron gate that leads to the city, which opened to them of its own accord; and they went out and went down one street, and immediately the angel departed from him.11 And when Peter had come to himself, he said, "Now I know for certain that the Lord has sent His angel, and has delivered me from the hand of Herod and from all the expectation of the Jewish people."

Paul and Silas at Philippi: Acts 16:22-30 (KJV) ***"And the multitude rose up together against them: and the magistrates rent off their clothes, and commanded to beat them. 23 And when they had laid many stripes upon them, they cast them into prison, charging the jailor to keep them safely: 24 Who, having received such a charge, thrust them into the inner prison, and made their feet fast in the stocks. 25 And <u>at midnight Paul and Silas prayed, and sang praises unto God</u>: and the prisoners heard them. 26 And <u>suddenly there was a great earthquake</u>, so that the foundations of the prison were shaken: and <u>immediately all the doors were opened, and every one's bands were loosed</u>. 27 And the keeper of the prison awaking out of his sleep, and seeing the prison doors open, he drew out his sword, and would have killed himself, supposing that the prisoners had been fled. 28 But Paul cried with a loud voice, saying, Do thyself no harm: for we are all here. 29***

Then he called for a light, and sprang in, and came trembling, and fell down before Paul and Silas, 30 And brought them out, and said, Sirs, what must I do to be saved?"

Faith as a gift deals with the unseen world and has far more to do with reality than the physical realm. Hebrews 11:1 (KJV) ***"Now faith is the substance*** (title deed-assurance) ***of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen."***

Faith as a gift is far superior to human reasoning or natural understanding. Neither human reasoning nor natural understanding can compel faith to function; in fact, it is the enemy of faith. Romans 8:5-9 (NKJV) ***"For those who live according to the flesh set their minds on the things of the flesh, but those who live according to the Spirit, the things of the Spirit.6 For to be carnally minded is death, but to be spiritually***

minded is life and peace.7 Because the carnal mind is enmity against God; for it is not subject to the law of God, nor indeed can be.8 So then, those who are in the flesh cannot please God.9 But you are not in the flesh but in the Spirit, if indeed the Spirit of God dwells in you. Now if anyone does not have the Spirit of Christ, he is not His."

The gift of faith produces a confidence in God and His word that defies human reasoning, satanic obstacles, doubt, and unbelief. It says I will believe no matter what, simply because God said it. When the gift of faith is functioning properly, it will produce the following things: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Supernatural blessing…
- Supernatural protection…
- Supernatural provision…
- Supernatural strength…

Faith is the switch that opens God's powerhouse. Faith sees the invisible, believes the incredible, and claims the impossible. Mark 11:22-24 (NKJV) ***"So Jesus answered and said to them, "Have faith in God.23 "For assuredly, I say to you, whoever says to this mountain, 'Be removed and be cast into the sea,' and does not doubt in his heart, but believes that those things he says will be done, he will have whatever he says.24 "Therefore I say to you, whatever things you ask when you pray, believe that you receive them, and you will have them."***

Faith is not a guarantee against problems… it is a guarantee against defeat!

Faith is not a state of mind, but a state of the heart toward God's Word. Romans 10:9-10 (KJV) ***"With the heart man believeth unto righteousness; and with the mouth confession is made unto salvation"***

PRACTICAL APPLICATION:

How are we to allow faith to operate in our lives? (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Develop imparted faith as far as it will take us… Study, educate yourself, take advantage of all educational opportunities.
- Develop the fruit of faith in our lives… Pray, Study His Word! Consume His Word! Stand on God's Word! Put God to the test!
- Discover His faithfulness…
- Ask God to allow the gift of faith to operate through us…
- Respond to the instructions of the Holy Spirit…
- Speak faith into faithless situations…

THE GIFTS OF THE SPIRIT
1 Corinthians 12:1-11

THE GIFTS OF HEALINGS - Vs. 9

During this study I want to attempt to address several commonly asked questions regarding this wonderful gift: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Is healing for today?
- Is it Gods will to heal everyone?
- Why do certain people receive their healing and others do not?
- Are the gifts of healings a one-size-fits-all proposition?
- How do I allow this wonderful gift to operate in my life?

First of all, is healing for today? Some people believe that the gifts ceased at the close of the apostolic age. Those who believe this normally use the following scripture to prove their point: 1 Corinthians 13:8-10 (NKJV) ***"Love never fails. But***

whether there are prophecies, <u>they will fail</u>; whether there are tongues, <u>they will cease</u>; whether there is knowledge, <u>it will vanish away</u>.9 For we know in part and we prophesy in part.10 But <u>when that which is perfect has come, then that which is in part will be done away</u>." Those who use this scripture to support their view of the gifts, also believe what the scripture is referring to when it says ***"when that which is perfect is come,"*** is the Bible.

I believe the Bible to be inerrant, but the Bible is certainly not what this scripture is speaking of. If this view were correct, not only would gifts have ceased with the completion of Holy Scripture, but knowledge would have been stymied as well. None of us could embrace a belief that says knowledge has not increased since the completion of the canon of scripture, yet many persist in believing gifts have ceased.

If knowledge is increasing, the use of gifts should be increasing as well.

Healing is a cardinal doctrine of the Word of God. Exodus 15:26 (KJV) ***"If thou wilt diligently hearken to the voice of the LORD thy God, and wilt do that which is right in his sight, and wilt give ear to his commandments, and keep all his statutes, I will put none of these diseases upon thee, which I have brought upon the Egyptians: for I am the LORD that healeth thee."***

This word ***"healeth"*** means the continuation of healing. He does not heal once and say, ***"that's all you get"*** but He ***"forgiveth all thine iniquities, and He healeth all thy diseases."*** This is a continuous action verb and means that as long as the need for forgiveness or healing exists, the gift will continue to be an active, viable gift.

Secondly, is it God's will to heal everyone? I am convinced the answer to this question is absolutely yes. From the fiery serpent in the wilderness through the apostolic age, there is iron clad scriptural proof that God's intentions were and are to heal everyone.

The following is a list of scriptures to consider:

- Numbers 21:8 Note the words ***"every one."***
- Matthew 12:15 ***"He healed them all."***
- Luke 4:40 ***"He laid His hands on every one of them, and healed them."***
- Luke 6:19 ***"He healed them all."***
- Luke 9:6 The Apostles ***"preached the Gospel and healed everywhere."***
- Luke 9:11 Jesus ***"healed them that had need of healing."***
- Acts 5:14-16 Multitudes who were sick and vexed with devils came to the ministry of Peter and vs. 16 says ***"and they were healed every one."***

The very first covenant the Lord made with the children of Israel after they left the land of Egypt was the Covenant of Healing. Exodus 15:26 (NKJV) ***"If you diligently heed the voice of the LORD your God and do what is right in His sight, give ear to His commandments and keep all His statutes, I will put none of the diseases on you which I have brought on the Egyptians. For I am the LORD who heals you."*** This covenant was a conditional covenant.

There were four conditions set forth for their healing: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Hear and obey the voice of the Lord thy God…
- Do that which is right in the sight of the Lord…
- Listen to his commandments…
- Keep all his laws…

God told them that if they would behave themselves and keep their end of the bargain, that He would keep His end of the covenant by taking care of their bodies. They struggled in fulfilling their part of the covenant, but God kept His part of the agreement. David tells us in Psalm 105:37(KJV) ***"He brought them forth also with silver and gold; and there was not one feeble person among their tribes."***

It is apparent that on multiple occasions all were healed. If this is true, then all can be healed now! Hebrews 13:8 (NKJV) ***"Jesus Christ is the same yesterday, today, and forever."***

Thirdly, why do some people get healed and others do not?

The only scriptural reasons I can find for people not being healed are a lack of faith, too much doubt, unbelief, or it is their time

to go. Even Jesus could not do many miracles in Nazareth because of the abundance of unbelief.

It is God's will to save everyone, but everyone is not saved. ***"He is not willing that any should perish, but that all should come to repentance."*** All are not saved because:

- Some have never heard that Jesus saves…
- Many have not been taught that He heals…
- Some do not believe salvation is for them…
- Some do not believe healing is for them…
- Unbelief doesn't bring healing any more than it brings salvation…
- Some fail to get saved because they refuse to meet the conditions set forth in the Word of God…

- Some do not get healed because they fail to meet the requirements of the Word of God…
- Some do not get saved because they cannot bring themselves to believe the finished work of Christ to be sufficient to forgive their sins…
- Some do not get healed because they cannot believe the work of Christ can become personal…

As born again believers, we should believe Christ is not only able to heal, but is also willing to heal. He is at least as willing as He is able!

Healing is provided for in the atonement. Isaiah 53:5 (NKJV) ***"But He was wounded for our transgressions, He was bruised for our iniquities; The chastisement for our peace was upon Him, And by His stripes we are healed."***

Are the Gifts of Healings a one-size-fits-all proposition? The answer to this question is no, absolutely not!

In 1 Corinthians 12, this gift is mentioned three times: in verse nine; in verse twenty-eight; and in verse thirty. In the King James Version the first noun is plural and the second is singular, but in the original, all three times, both appear in the plural form. The plurality of both nouns in the sentence seems to point up the possibility of many gifts of healings for many different diseases.

The use of every day examples to teach spiritual truth can be risky and somewhat inadequate but Jesus found it necessary to resort to such tactics in order to impart spiritual truth. So allow me to use the following example. In the medical field there are general practitioners and there are specialists. A family doctor is more than likely a general practitioner and unless we

have a serious or prolonged illness, he will normally be able to walk us through most of our health issues. However, when our health problems go beyond normal and routine maladies, our primary care physician will refer us to a specialist.

If we break a foot we do not go to see our good friend who is an oncologist, we go to see an orthopedic surgeon.

One of the problems with the modern day church is that we have a tendency to generalize, painting everything with a really broad brush. We like our religion in a one-size-fits-all package. We deal in generalities far too often, setting ourselves up for failure to seize and receive the miraculous. God desires to allow us to see the miraculous but He normally reserves the miraculous for those who deal with Him in specifics rather than generalities.

Following the miracle of the loaves and the fish, Jesus sent His disciples away by ship on the Sea of Galilee. During the course of their voyage, an unexpected wind began to threaten the ship. Jesus saw them ***"straining at rowing"*** and walks on the sea in close proximity to the ship. Notice St. Mark's description of the event: Mark 6:48-49 (NKJV) ***"Then He saw them straining at rowing, for the wind was against them. Now about the fourth watch of the night He came to them, walking on the sea, and <u>would have passed them by</u>.49 And when they saw Him walking on the sea, they supposed it was a ghost, and <u>cried out</u>;"***

Look at the story of the Leper in Matthew chapter eight: Matthew 8:1-3 (NKJV) ***"When He had come down from the mountain, great multitudes followed Him.2 And behold, a leper came and worshiped Him, saying, "<u>Lord, if You are willing, You can make me clean</u>."3 Then Jesus put out***

His hand and touched him, saying, "<u>I am willing; be cleansed</u>." <u>Immediately his leprosy was cleansed</u>."

Again, the Gifts of Healings, as you can readily see, are in the double plural tense. It is the only one of the nine spiritual gifts grammatically constructed in this way. My experience in kingdom work lets me know that those who function in a gift of healing often feel more drawn to pray with persons with a particular disease than to pray for various other diseases. This is certainly not set in stone, but is normally the case. Here is the revelation of my understanding: there are as many gifts of healing as there are diseases. Within every body of believers there should be a gift of healing for every disease.

There are no incurable diseases with the Lord. No one is hopeless, nothing is too hard

for the Lord, and all things are possible to those who believe.

God can certainly manifest any one of His gifts through anyone who will yield to it. Because we are human, we may have a greater level of faith to pray for one disease over another. In such a case it becomes even more important that all function in the area of their giftedness.

There are some who know they have a healing ministry, yet become grieved and burdened when all manner of sicknesses and diseases do not yield to their prayers or commands.

I think we could say with a definite degree of certainty that the gifts of healings are certainly not a one-size-fits-all proposition.

How are we to allow this wonderful gift to operate in our lives and ministries? In order

to discover the proper usage of this gift, we need only to look at the life and ministry of Jesus.

One of the interesting features of the ministry of Jesus is that the scripture repeatedly points up the fact that He was ***"moved with compassion"*** toward the plight of others. Nine times in the four gospels the word compassion is used to describe Jesus' dealings with individuals or multitudes. Oftentimes this resulted in people receiving their healing:

- Matthew 14:14 (NKJV) ***"And when Jesus went out He saw a great multitude; and He was moved with compassion for them, and healed their sick."***
- Matthew 20:29-34 (NKJV) ***"Now as they went out of Jericho, a great multitude followed Him.30 And behold, two blind men sitting by the road, when they heard that Jesus was passing by,***

cried out, saying, "Have mercy on us, O Lord, Son of David!"31 Then the multitude warned them that they should be quiet; but they cried out all the more, saying, "Have mercy on us, O Lord, Son of David!"32 So Jesus stood still and called them, and said, "What do you want Me to do for you?"33 They said to Him, "Lord, that our eyes may be opened."34 So <u>Jesus had compassion and touched their eyes. And immediately their eyes received sight, and they followed Him</u>."

- Mark 1:40-42 (NKJV) ***"Now a leper came to Him, imploring Him, kneeling down to Him and saying to Him, "If You are willing, You can make me clean."41 Then <u>Jesus, moved with compassion, stretched out His hand and touched him, and said to him, "I am willing; be cleansed."42 As soon as He had spoken, immediately the leprosy left him, and he was cleansed</u>."***

Those who have received the gifts of healings must learn to recognize the prompting of the Holy Spirit and allow the timely operation of this gift in all situations. Those who have received this gift: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Will know the gift is in operation in their life…
- Will know what area of illness they are drawn to pray for...
- Will recognize the prompting of the Holy Spirit when they are to pray for certain people for certain reasons… (In Jesus' ministry it was called compassion)
- Will have a genuine desire to be used in the gift...
- Will seek out opportunities to allow for the usage of the gift…

The modern day church is in dire need of the manifestation of this wonderful gift. It is time for local churches and pastors to train,

equip, and empower the people to step out in faith especially in the operation of the gifts. Matthew 10:5-8 (NKJV) ***"These twelve Jesus sent out and commanded them, saying: "Do not go into the way of the Gentiles, and do not enter a city of the Samaritans.6 "But go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.7 "And as you go, preach, saying, 'The kingdom of heaven is at hand.'8 "Heal the sick, cleanse the lepers, raise the dead, cast out demons. Freely you have received, freely give."***

PRACTICAL APPLICATION:

The following guidelines must be remembered and followed in the usage of this wonderful gift: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Seek the gift… (Ask God to allow this gift to work in our lives)
- Before laying hands on an individual ask for the gift to work through us…

- Be sensitive to the prompting of the Holy Spirit and obey, no matter how ridiculous it may seem… (Know when to act and when to be silent)
- Pray in faith, never allowing doubt to cloud our thoughts...
- Speak any words of faith God places in our hearts…

THE GIFTS OF THE SPIRIT
1 Corinthians 12:1-11

THE WORKING OF MIRACLES - Vs. 10, 28-29

The gift we are about to study is a much-needed commodity in our world. Everyone I know either needs a miracle or is connected to someone who does.

The first thing I would like to point out is the terminology of scripture with regard to this wonderful gift. I believe every phrase in scripture is thoughtfully and purposefully framed. For instance, in this study we learned that the normal way of stating ***"the gift of healing"*** is improper, and is more properly stated ***"the gifts of healings"*** because there are as many gifts of healing as there are diseases. In this particular instance it is not ***"the gift of miracles"***, it is ***"the gift of working of miracles."*** In this study we

are going to discover why this gift is termed in such a manner.

The definition of this gift is as follows: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Working – Energema… (en-erg'-ay-mah) Active, efficient operation.
- Miracles – Dunamis… (doo'-nam-is) Miraculous power or ability…

Based on this information, we could define this gift as the active, efficient operation of miraculous powers or abilities.

In his book *"The Gifts of the Spirit,"* Harold Horton defines miracles in the following ways: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- "A miracle is a supernatural act on the natural plane."
- "Works contrary to nature, accomplishments, so to speak, of the impossible, sudden and unaccountable

reversals of the order to which we are accustomed."

- "A miracle is a supernatural intervention in the ordinary course of nature; a temporary suspension of the accustomed order; an interruption of the system of nature as we know it."
- "A miracle is a sovereign act of the Spirit of God irrespective of laws or systems."

Before we move on to other things, let me add that the gift of the working of miracles has to do with miracles of a non-physical nature rather than a physical nature. When we talk about a person having experienced a miracle of healing, it could more correctly be identified as a gift of healing.

In scripture the gift of the working of miracles would be instances such as:
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- God speaking the world into existence…

- God creating man…
- Abram's ram caught in a thicket…
- The plagues of Egypt…
- The Red Sea being parted…
- The brazen serpent in the wilderness
- The provision of food and water in the wilderness…
- The forty-year life span of clothing and sandals in the time of the wilderness wandering…
- Gideon's fleece being wet or dry…
- Elijah's fire on Carmel…
- The widow's oil being multiplied…
- Jesus turning water into wine…
- Tax money being found in the mouth of a fish…
- The stormy sea being stilled with three words…
- The apostles being freed from prison…

We all know God to be a God of miracles. To be used in this important gift, we must move beyond the belief that He is able to

believing He wants to use us to work His miracles. The most important thing for us to understand concerning this gift is that the gift has more to do with the worker of miracles than it does with the need for a miracle or the willingness on God's part to furnish the power for the miracle.

No doubt about it, God desires to furnish miracles in our midst and there is certainly an overabundance of needs for miracles. So the question becomes, how do I get myself into a position to be used in the working of miracles?

Miracles go beyond the natural to the supernatural. Having said that, I must also say that God is not the only one who can operate in the supernatural:

- Pharaoh's magicians were able to cause their rods to become snakes…
- Pharaoh's magicians were able to turn the water to blood…

- Pharaoh's magicians were able to bring frogs upon the land…
- Pharaoh's magicians were able to turn dust into lice…

Pharaoh's magicians had the power to punish the land, but they did not have the power to bless it by ridding it of pestilence. Simply put, the devil and his cronies can operate in the supernatural, but they cannot complete a work that results in good things happening to God's people.

In addition, he cannot curse what God has blessed as long as the person who has been blessed stays within the protection God has provided. The devil can't curse what God has blessed, which means the only way for a Christian to be cursed is for them to curse themselves!

Miracles should never in and of themselves be considered proof of the Godliness of the

person through whom they flow. A person should never be considered Godly based solely on the deeds they are able to do. The acquisition of the fruit of the Spirit in the life of the individual in question and the operation of the gift of discerning of spirits on the part of the person doing the questioning is needed to determine the spirituality and Godliness of those who claim to be from God.

When the gift of working of miracles is in operation, natural laws are often set aside to bring about the provision, protection, and advancement of the people of God.

The working of miracles is a result of God setting aside His laws of nature, allowing the higher Spiritual laws to take control. The regular laws are not abandoned, but merely set aside for the time being as the greater laws of God come into operation to supersede them:

- The law of conflagration was set-aside in the miracle of the burning bush…
- The law of death was set-aside in the miracle of the translation of Enoch and Elijah...
- The law of process was set-aside in the miracle of water being turned to wine…
- The law of gravity was set-aside in the miracle of the ascension…

These natural laws being circumvented are not only referred to in the Bible as miracles, but also as powers, signs, and wonders. Harold Horton in his book *"The Gifts of the Spirit"* gives the following definitions:
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Powers - Explosions of almightiness…
- Signs - The visible tokens of invisible power…
- Wonders - Impelling staggering astonishment…

Harold Horton says *"The gift of the working of miracles operates by the energy or dynamic force of the spirit in reversals or suspensions of natural laws."*

The God of the Bible is no doubt almighty and all-powerful. There is nothing He cannot do for those who trust Him wholly. When God works a miracle, we are awed by His ability to defy human limitations and the laws of nature. In God's world, performing a miracle, no matter how difficult it may seem, is just His natural and normal way of doing things. To understand this truth fully, one must understand one fundamental, foundational truth: He is not a God who performs miracles; He is a God of miracles. It was more natural for Jesus to walk on water than not to walk on it!

By His very nature, God is more apt to perform a miracle than not to perform it.

I am a minister. Sermon preparation is what I do. I've been preparing sermons on a weekly basis for more than thirty-five years, and though it takes a little time, sermon preparation is so much a part of my life that if I have a week where I am not preparing a sermon, I feel incomplete. After thirty-five years of ministry, sermon preparation comes naturally for me.

For God, miracles are the natural way of doing things. It does not take any more ability and power for God to do the miraculous than it does for us to perform the daily duties of our professions.

From Genesis to Revelation, the Bible is full of miracles. The very act of creation was miraculous; the final disposition of the earth will be miraculous; the creation of man was miraculous; and the final fate of man will also be miraculous.

Certainly the incidents of miracles are more prominent in the Old Testament than in the New Testament, especially if you exclude physical healing from the list. However, there is no question that miracles are for today, and the need for miracles is unprecedented. If miracles are so desperately needed, the importance of this gift becomes crucial to the contemporary church.

Notice the terminology of Scripture with regard to this gift:

- 1 Corinthians 12:10 (NKJV) ***"To another the working of miracles, to another prophecy, to another discerning of spirits, to another different kinds of tongues, to another the interpretation of tongues."***
- 1 Corinthians 12:28-29 (NKJV) ***"And God has appointed these in the church: first apostles, second prophets, third teachers, after that miracles, then gifts***

of healings, helps, administrations, varieties of tongues.29 Are all apostles? Are all prophets? Are all teachers? Are all workers of miracles?"

Remember, according to Strong's Concordance, the word working or worker here is Energema (en-erg'-ay-mah), meaning active, efficient operation. In his book *"The Gifts of the Spirit,"* Harold Horton states, *"Those who produce such works through this gift are strikingly called by a word in the Greek that might be rendered 'miraclers', or, perhaps better, 'miraclers' of miracles."* Miracles - Dunamis - (doo'-nam-is) *"Miraculous power or ability."*

More times than not when a miracle occurred in the Word of God, it happened either in direct response to the Word being spoken, prayer, or a direct act of obedience on the part of a human being.

- God speaking the world into existence - The Word being spoken…
- God creating man - The Word being spoken - The breath of God…
- Abram's ram caught in a thicket - Obedience on the part of Abram…
- The plagues of Egypt - Obedience on the part of Moses and Aaron and the Word being spoken…
- The Red Sea being parted - Obedience on the part of Moses - He stretched his rod out over the sea…
- The brazen serpent in the wilderness - Obedience on the part of Moses…
- The provision of food and water in the wilderness - Obedience on the part of the Israelites - They moved with the cloud and fire…
- The 40 year life span of clothing and sandals in the time of the wilderness wandering - Obedience on the part of the Israelites - They kept moving with the cloud and fire…

- Gideon's fleece being wet or dry – Prayer…
- Elijah's fire on Carmel - Obedience - Speaking the Word of God…
- The widow's oil being multiplied - The Word of God being spoken by the prophet Elisha - Obedience on the part of the widow…
- Jesus turning water into wine - Mary made a request and Jesus spoke the Word - Word was spoken - Obedience - He told them to *"Fill the water-pots with water,"* they did so and He said *"Draw out now and bear unto the governor of the feast."* They did so and the water was changed to wine…
- Tax money being found in the mouth of a fish – Obedience…
- The stormy sea being stilled with three words - The word was spoken…
- The apostles being freed from prison – Prayer - Obedience…

Based on this information, I believe we could safely say there are three essential ingredients in the DNA of a worker of miracles: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Prayer…
- The Word… (Learn it & speak it)
- Obedience…

Though the personal lifestyle and commitment of the individual being used as a worker of miracles is very important, it is not the deciding factor of whether a miracle will occur or will not occur. In the Bible, God once used a donkey to do His work and He most certainly used people who had feet of clay:

- Abram lied…
- Moses was at times an unwilling worker, and disobeyed in the striking of the rock…
- Gideon doubted…
- Elijah backslid…

- The apostles were at times undependable…
- Peter denied Christ three times in one night and capped it off with foul language…

God is not really looking for perfect people! He is looking for willing, yielded vessels.

PRACTICAL APPLICATION:
The following guidelines should be remembered and followed in the usage of this wonderful gift: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Seek the gift… Ask God to use us to bring about a miracle.
- Be sensitive to the Holy Spirit with regard to when, where, and how He wants to bring about a miracle.
- Allow faith rather than fear to dominate our thoughts.
- Be obedient to the instructions of the Holy Spirit.

- Speak the Word in faith with boldness.

* Harold Horton, The Gifts of the Spirit - Letchworth Printers LTD., Letchworth, Herts, Englnd

* Strong's exhaustive concordance of the Bible

THE GIFTS OF THE SPIRIT
1 Corinthians 12:1-11

UTTERANCE GIFTS

DIVERS KINDS OF TONGUES - vs. 10
The gift we are about to study is possibly the most difficult of all the gifts to teach, simply because it is widely practiced by people who have a limited understanding of its proper Biblical operation. We would be hard pressed to find very many people in a Pentecostal or charismatic church who would admit to not knowing the reason for, and the proper operation of this gift. A closer study of the aptitude of the general public within the same churches would no doubt reveal a huge deficiency in the Biblical knowledge of the guidelines that govern the proper operation of this gift. As a result of assumed knowledge, this gift is probably the most often abused of all the gifts.

Going all the way back to the first family of the human race, it is apparent in Scripture that God gave Adam a mother tongue or universal language with which he communicated with his wife and family. Every person born in the line of Adam spoke this universal language. Because of the sin of pride and arrogance, God confounded the languages at the tower of Babel. With the confounding of the languages, the population of the earth began to be segregated into little population pockets of language friendly people. This language barrier redefined the geographical locality of the human race, causing them to settle their families in previously unexplored lands.

Isn't it ironic that divers kinds of tongues were first imparted to a group of heathens who were attempting to reach heaven fraudulently? An interesting note is that divers kinds of tongues were first imparted

to heathens who immediately went into all the world.

In the New Testament, Jesus prophesied the arrival of the Holy Spirit and stated that when they received Him they would have power to become witnesses to the entire world. Acts 1:8 (NKJV) ***"But you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you shall be witnesses to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."***

In this study we are going to explore:
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The initial physical evidence of Holy Spirit baptism…
- Unknown tongues…
- Divers kinds of tongues…
- The gift of tongues…

EVIDENCE

I want to begin by talking about the initial physical evidence of Holy Spirit baptism. The gift of the Holy Spirit is available to every born again believer. The Holy Spirit is not given in response to a threshold of personal holiness achieved by the believer.

The Holy Spirit is given to provide the believer with extra power along with a host of other reasons, one of which is that the believer could communicate with the Father in the Father's language.

The gift of the Holy Spirit is subsequent to salvation. Many believe they received the Holy Spirit when they received Christ. This is in part true; when we were converted, the Holy Spirit came along side us. He actually seals us against the day of redemption. Ephesians 1:13-14 (NKJV) ***"In Him you also trusted, after you heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation; in whom also, having believed, you were***

sealed with the Holy Spirit of promise,14 who is the guarantee of our inheritance until the redemption of the purchased possession, to the praise of His glory." John 14:15-17 (NKJV) ***"If you love Me, keep My commandments.16 "And I will pray the Father, and He will give you another Helper, that He may abide with you forever—17 "the Spirit of truth, whom the world cannot receive, because it neither sees Him nor knows Him; but you know Him, for He dwells with you and will be in you."***

Once we are sealed with the Holy Spirit of promise, we are only a step away from entering into the gateway of God's giftedness. There is strong Scriptural evidence of the Holy Spirit being a second definite work of grace apart from, and subsequent to, conversion. Acts 19:1-7 (NKJV) ***"And it happened, while Apollos was at Corinth, that Paul, having passed***

through the upper regions, came to Ephesus. And finding some disciples 2 he said to them, "Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?" So they said to him, "We have not so much as heard whether there is a Holy Spirit."3 And he said to them, "Into what then were you baptized?" So they said, "Into John's baptism."4 Then Paul said, "John indeed baptized with a baptism of repentance, saying to the people that they should believe on Him who would come after him, that is, on Christ Jesus."5 When they heard this, they were baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus.6 And when Paul had laid hands on them, the Holy Spirit came upon them, and they spoke with tongues and prophesied.7 Now the men were about twelve in all."

The initial outpouring in the upper room featured all 120 present speaking in tongues. Acts 2:1-4 (NKJV) ***"When the Day of***

Pentecost had fully come, they were all with one accord in one place.2 And suddenly there came a sound from heaven, as of a rushing mighty wind, and it filled the whole house where they were sitting.3 Then there appeared to them divided tongues, as of fire, and <u>one sat upon each of them</u>.4 And <u>they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance.</u>"

If I rightly divide Acts 2, the first physical evidence that these believers had received the promise of the Father was the fact they spoke in tongues.

Why do you suppose the Father chose to use <u>tongues</u> as the initial physical sign of the baptism in the Holy Spirit? James 3:3-9 (NKJV) ***"Indeed, we put bits in horses' mouths that they may obey us, and we turn their whole body.4 Look also at ships:***

although they are so large and are driven by fierce winds, they are turned by a very small rudder wherever the pilot desires.5 Even so the tongue is a little member and boasts great things. See how great a forest a little fire kindles! 6 And the tongue is a fire, a world of iniquity. The tongue is so set among our members that it defiles the whole body, and sets on fire the course of nature; and it is set on fire by hell.7 For every kind of beast and bird, of reptile and creature of the sea, is tamed and has been tamed by mankind.8 But no man can tame the tongue. It is an unruly evil, full of deadly poison.9 With it we bless our God and Father, and with it we curse men, who have been made in the similitude of God."

Considering this Scripture, it appears the tongue is the most difficult member of the body to bring under subjection to the will of man and of God. Thus, if a person can surrender their tongue to God, they have,

without question, surrendered completely. When a person surrenders completely to God, they are baptized in the Holy Spirit and speak in tongues.

The question should be asked, is there sufficient Scriptural evidence of tongues being the first physical indication of a believer being baptized in the Holy Spirit? Take a walk with me through the book of Acts: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Acts 2:1-4... The Upper room - They spoke in tongues - (NKJV) ***"When the Day of Pentecost had fully come, they were all with one accord in one place.2 And suddenly there came a sound from heaven, as of a rushing mighty wind, and it filled the whole house where they were sitting.3 Then there appeared to them divided tongues, as of fire, and one sat upon each of them.4 And <u>they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and</u>***

began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance."

- Acts 8:15-18… Believers in Samaria - (NKJV) ***"Now when the apostles who were at Jerusalem heard that Samaria had received the word of God, they sent Peter and John to them,15 who, when they had come down, prayed for them that they might receive the Holy Spirit.16 For as yet He had fallen upon none of them. They had only been baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus.17 Then they laid hands on them, and they received the Holy Spirit.18 And when Simon saw that through the laying on of the apostles' hands the Holy Spirit was given, he offered them money, 19 saying, "Give me this power also, that anyone on whom I lay hands may receive the Holy Spirit."***
- Acts 9:17-18… The Apostle Paul - (NKJV) ***"And Ananias went his way and entered the house; and laying his***

hands on him he said, "Brother Saul, the Lord Jesus, who appeared to you on the road as you came, has sent me that you <u>may receive your sight and be filled with the Holy Spirit</u>."18 <u>Immediately there fell from his eyes something like scales, and he received his sight at once; and he arose and was baptized.</u>" This passage does not say that (Saul) Paul spoke in tongues, but listen to his later comments. 1 Corinthians 14:18 (NKJV) ***"I thank my God, <u>I speak with tongues more than ye all</u>:"***

- Acts 10:44-46... The house of Cornelius - (NKJV) ***"While Peter was still speaking these words, <u>the Holy Spirit fell upon all those who heard the word</u>.45 And those of the circumcision who believed were astonished, as many as came with Peter, because the gift of the Holy Spirit had been poured out on the Gentiles also.46 For <u>they heard</u>***

<u>them speak with tongues</u> and magnify God…"

- Acts 19:1-7… Believers at Ephesus – (NKJV) ***"And it happened, while Apollos was at Corinth, that Paul, having passed through the upper regions, came to Ephesus. And finding some disciples2 he said to them, "Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?" So they said to him, "We have not so much as heard whether there is a Holy Spirit."3 And he said to them, "Into what then were you baptized?" So they said, "Into John's baptism."4 Then Paul said, "John indeed baptized with a baptism of repentance, saying to the people that they should believe on Him who would come after him, that is, on Christ Jesus."5 When they heard this, they were baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus.6 And when <u>Paul had laid hands on them, the Holy Spirit came upon</u>***

them, and they spoke with tongues and prophesied.7 Now the men were about twelve in all."

Each time an individual or group of people were baptized in the Holy Spirit in the book of Acts, the Scripture either says directly that they spoke in tongues, or there was some kind of physical manifestation that alerted those in close proximity that they had been filled with the Spirit. I believe the physical manifestation was speaking in tongues.

I further believe that every single person who has been filled with the Holy Spirit from Acts 2 until today have spoken in tongues immediately.

UNKNOWN TONGUE

Having established that tongues is in fact the first physical evidence that a person has actually received the infilling of the Holy

Spirit, we must ask, what kind of tongues does the believer receive in that initial experience?

Generally speaking, I believe the individual receives an unknown tongue. This in turn establishes a prayer language for the believer to use, to build themselves up in their most holy faith. Jude 20-21 (NKJV) ***"But you, beloved, building yourselves up on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Spirit,21 keep yourselves in the love of God, looking for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ unto eternal life."***

The initial outpouring of the Holy Spirit in the upper room featured the 120 actually speaking in divers kinds of tongues. Acts 2:1-8 (KJV) ***"And when the day of Pentecost was fully come, they were all with one accord in one place. 2 And suddenly there came a sound from heaven as of a rushing mighty wind, and it filled***

all the house where they were sitting. 3 And there appeared unto them cloven tongues like as of fire, and it sat upon each of them. 4 And they were all filled with the Holy Ghost, and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance. 5 "And there were dwelling at Jerusalem Jews, devout men, out of every nation under heaven. 6 Now when this was noised abroad, the multitude came together, and were confounded, because that every man heard them speak in his own language. 7 And they were all amazed and marveled, saying one to another, Behold, are not all these which speak Galilaeans? 8 And how hear we every man in our own tongue, wherein we were born?"

This is the only place I can find in the Bible that new believers speak in anything other than an unknown tongue. Every occasion subsequent to this initial outpouring in the upper room, where the Scripture records that

an individual received the infilling of the Holy Spirit, there is no reference made to anyone present understanding the language they were speaking.

After careful study, I believe there may have been three separate things happening in Acts 2: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- These people were filled with the Holy Spirit in the upper room - I can't say for sure, but I believe they initially spoke in an unknown tongue -Acts 2:4 (NKJV) ***"And they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance."***
- They vacated the upper room and attracted the public - Acts 2:6 (KJV) ***"Now when this was noised abroad, the multitude came together..."***
- Once they left the Upper Room and entered the streets of Jerusalem, the

general public heard them speak in various languages - The Gift of Tongues employing the use of divers kinds of tongues is obviously in operation here - Acts 2:6-8 (KJV) ***"Now when this was noised abroad, the multitude came together, and were confounded, because that every man heard them speak in his own language. 7 And they were all amazed and marveled, saying one to another, Behold, are not all these which speak Galileans? 8 And how hear we every man in our own tongue, wherein we were born?"***

The unknown tongue is exactly as it is stated in the Bible: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- It is unknown to the believer…
- It is unknown to those present…
- It is unknown to all other nationalities…
- It is unknown to the enemy…

DIVERS KINDS OF TONGUES

Very simply put, divers kinds of tongues, is the use of the languages of the world through an individual who has never studied or committed to memory that particular language.

As you know, learning a second language can be very difficult and requires a commitment of time and resources. Some of you are fluent in multiple languages, and you can appreciate the effort and time that goes into being bilingual

If I were to tell those of you who are bilingual that in the natural I can fluently speak English, Spanish, and French without ever having studied the languages, you would laugh me out of the room. It would literally be impossible to do such a thing in the natural.

Remember, that which is impossible in the natural is oftentimes made possible in the spiritual.

The languages of the world are employed through the knowledge of the Holy Spirit during the implementation of the gift of divers kinds of tongues.

The Scripture makes reference to tongues being a sign to the unbeliever. 1 Corinthians 14:22 (NKJV) ***"Therefore tongues are for a sign, not to those who believe but to unbelievers; but prophesying is not for unbelievers but for those who believe."***

How is this possible? When a believer speaks in tongues it is a sign to the unbeliever that the individual has been baptized in the Holy Spirit.

A believer speaking in a language they have never learned, which happens to be the

native language of the unbeliever, can have a very effective impact on the unbeliever (HAVE BRO. RIEKERT GIVE HIS TESTIMONY)

A believer speaking in a language they have never learned, followed by the gift of interpretation of tongues, often speaks directly to the unbeliever concerning particular events in their life

THE GIFT OF TONGUES

The gift of tongues is a gift apart from the infilling of the Holy Spirit. There is strong Scriptural authentication that when a person is baptized in the Holy Spirit they speak in tongues. The gift of tongues is a separate gift of the Spirit that God has offered to all believers.

While speaking in an unknown tongue is given to edify the individual believer, the gift of tongues is given for the reason of

edifying the church. 1 Corinthians 14:1-4 (KJV) ***"Follow after charity, and desire spiritual gifts, but rather that ye may prophesy. 2 For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue speaketh not unto men, but unto God: for no man understandeth him; howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries. 3 But he that prophesieth speaketh unto men to edification, and exhortation, and comfort. 4 He that speaketh in an unknown tongue edifieth himself; but he that prophesieth edifieth the church"*** In this Scripture we see the distinction between an unknown tongue and diverse kinds of tongues being manifested as the gift of tongues. The use of diverse kinds of tongues is employed in the operation of the gift of tongues because it is to be followed by the gift of interpretation of tongues.

If one is to be used in this wonderful gift, the following procedures should be closely followed:

- Pray to be used in this important gift…
- Pray for special sensitivity to the Holy Spirit to know when to speak and when to be silent…
- Remember, God will never interrupt one anointing with another anointing…
- When one gives a message in tongues they are to silently await the interpretation…
- When one has given a message in tongues and there is no interpretation, they are to pray that the Holy Spirit would give them the interpretation…

When one has given a message in tongues and there is no interpretation and they have prayed that the Holy Spirit would give them the interpretation and He has not; they should not repeat the message in tongues without there first being an interpretation. I

Corinthians 14:27 (NKJV) ***"If any man speak in an unknown tongue, let it be by two, or at the most by three, and that by course; and let one interpret."***

PRACTICAL APPLICATION:
Remember the following facts concerning tongues: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Tongues are the initial physical evidence of Holy Spirit baptism…
- Speaking in an unknown tongue is essential to the spiritual development of the believer… 1 Corinthians 14:4 (NKJV) ***"He who speaks in a tongue edifies himself, but he who prophesies edifies the church."*** Jude 20 (NKJV) ***"But you, beloved, building yourselves up on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Spirit,"***
- Speaking in an unknown tongue is to be limited in the corporate church… 1 Corinthians 14:28 (NKJV) ***"But if there***

is no interpreter, let him keep silent in church, and let him speak to himself and to God."

- The unknown tongue should be frequently employed in the private prayer time of each believer… 1 Corinthians 14:18 (NKJV) ***"I thank my God, I speak with tongues more than ye all:"*** During my walk with God as a Spirit filled believer, there have been several times that the gift of tongues operated in my private prayer time followed by the interpretation - each time this occurred, I received Divine direction concerning specific situations.
- The gift of tongues can be employed in small groups…
- The gift of tongues should be employed in the corporate church…
- When the gift of tongues is employed in the corporate church, the number of occurrences is limited by Scriptural mandate… 1 Corinthians 14:27-29

(NKJV) ***"If anyone speaks in a tongue, let there be <u>two or at the most three</u>, <u>each in turn, and let one interpret</u>.28 But if there is no interpreter, let him keep silent in church, and let him speak to himself and to God.29 Let two or three prophets speak, and let the others judge."***

THE GIFTS OF THE SPIRIT
1 Corinthians 12:1-11

INTERPRETATION OF TONGUES - Vs. 10

Interpretation of tongues is the supernatural ability to interpret a language that we have never learned. This gift is certainly not the translation of a language that has been learned in advance by the person doing the interpreting; it is the divine ability to translate from a language not known by the interpreter to a language known both by the interpreter and all others within the audience.

For a person to be able to translate a language he does not himself understand is nothing short of a gift from God; this gift always follows an utterance of divers kinds of tongues, thus, we refer to it as the gift of interpretation of tongues.

An extremely interesting note is that seven of these gifts were periodically manifested in the Old Testament and frequently employed in the New Testament. The seven include: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The word of wisdom…
- The word of knowledge…
- Discerning of spirits…
- The gift of faith…
- Gifts of healings…
- The gift of miracles…
- The gift of prophesy…

Tongues and interpretation of tongues are exclusive to the New Testament. When Jesus established His church, he gifted it to have a supernatural order of ministry. In so doing, He gifted it with the giftedness that had been an identifying mark of His presence in the Old Testament, and then added these two wonderful gifts: tongues and interpretation of tongues.

Because of the gifts He gave, His church would then be adequate to any task it was called upon to perform. The church is never as powerful as it is when it is flowing in the giftedness and power of the Holy Spirit. The church is genetically engineered to rely on a supernatural order of ministry to accomplish its purpose in the earth.

Because of its supernatural gifting, Jesus had this to say of his church... Matthew 16:18-19 (KJV) ***"And I say also unto thee, that thou art Peter, and upon this rock I will build my church; and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it. 19 And I will give unto thee the keys of the kingdom of heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt bind on earth shall be bound in heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven."***

The gift of interpretation of tongues is one of the nine spiritual gifts God programmed into the genetic makeup of His church to give it a marked advantage in its battle against sin. The supernatural ability to translate or interpret the language that has been spoken in other tongues is nothing short of a modern day miracle.

The aspect of this gift that makes it very different from an interpreter who is translating a language he has mastered in the natural is the fact that, apart from the Holy Spirit, the interpreter cannot comprehend the language that has been used to bring forth the message in tongues.

Even though the interpreter cannot grasp the meaning of the message that has been given with his intellect, the Holy Spirit reveals the interpretation to him. Therefore, it is not necessary for him to understand the message in order to interpret it!

I realize this sounds extreme, but God is not limited by our intellect! Balaam's donkey in the Old Testament book of Numbers can powerfully illustrate this truth. Balaam agreed to go with Balak to Moab even though he knew it was not God's will for him to do so... Numbers 22:22-31 (NKJV) ***"Then God's anger was aroused because he went, and the Angel of the LORD took His stand in the way as an adversary against him. And he was riding on his donkey, and his two servants were with him.23 Now the donkey saw the Angel of the LORD standing in the way with His drawn sword in His hand, and the donkey turned aside out of the way and went into the field. So Balaam struck the donkey to turn her back onto the road.24 Then the Angel of the LORD stood in a narrow path between the vineyards, with a wall on this side and a wall on that side.25 And when the donkey saw the Angel of the LORD, she pushed herself against the wall and***

crushed Balaam's foot against the wall; so he struck her again.26 Then the Angel of the LORD went further, and stood in a narrow place where there was no way to turn either to the right hand or to the left.27 And when the donkey saw the Angel of the LORD, she lay down under Balaam; so Balaam's anger was aroused, and he struck the donkey with his staff.28 Then the LORD opened the mouth of the donkey, and she said to Balaam, "What have I done to you, that you have struck me these three times?"29 And Balaam said to the donkey, "Because you have abused me. I wish there were a sword in my hand, for now I would kill you!"30 So the donkey said to Balaam, "Am I not your donkey on which you have ridden, ever since I became yours, to this day? Was I ever disposed to do this to you?" And he said, "No."(The KJV say's "NAY") ***31 Then the LORD opened Balaam's eyes, and he saw the Angel of the LORD standing in the way with His drawn***

sword in His hand; and he bowed his head and fell flat on his face."

As with all the other gifts, this gift is not about the intelligence or worthiness of the individual being used… it is about God's attempts to communicate with his people.

The modern day church has focused more on the personalities and qualifications of the gifted rather than focusing on the validity and usefulness of the gift!

Tongues always precede interpretation of tongues; however, interpretation of tongues does not always follow after tongues (Unknown tongues). Therefore, tongues are not dependent on interpretation of tongues but interpretation of tongues is solely dependent upon tongues. Tongues as a gift of the spirit are absolutely dependent on interpretation of tongues.

In 1 Corinthians Paul goes to great lengths to establish perimeters for the regulations of these gifts. 1 Corinthians 14:1-5 (KJV)
"Follow after charity, and desire spiritual gifts, but rather that ye may prophesy. 2 For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue speaketh not unto men, but unto God: for no man understandeth him; howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries. 3 But he that prophesieth speaketh unto men to edification, and exhortation, and comfort. 4 He that speaketh in an unknown tongue edifieth himself; but he that prophesieth edifieth the church. 5 I would that ye all spake with tongues, but rather that ye prophesied: for greater is he that prophesieth than he that speaketh with tongues, except he interpret, that the church may receive edifying."

The regulations of the gifts are established with the edification of the body at the heart of the entire matter.

God never suffocates the personality, temperament, training, or natural gifts of an individual when using them to communicate His message.

For instance:

- Moses' training in the palace of Egypt was beneficial to his role as a leader during forty plus years of wilderness wandering.
- David's training as a shepherd comes shining through in the Psalms.
- Luke's training as a physician reveals itself in his gospel.
- Paul's religious training reveals itself from time to time in his epistles.
- Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John tell the same basic stories in four very different ways.

While these gifts do not flow out of the intellect, the personality, the temperament, the training, and the natural gifts, all of these

will certainly come shining through during the operation of the gifts.

As a pastor, oftentimes I have had the following experiences. A message in tongues is given in a public service - I received the interpretation but did not feel that I was the one to give the interpretation. Someone else interpreted the message in tongues, but the interpretation was not word for word what I received, but the general message was the same.

Why does this happen? God is operating his gift through a vessel that has its own personality, temperament, training, and natural gifts, and he will never suffocate those things when communicating his message.

The general message was revealed to me as the human authority over that particular body of believers for the purpose of judging

the message in light of the Scripture and the revelation of the Holy Spirit.

The revelation of an interpretation of tongues can be received in many ways. The following list will identify some of them: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- A Scripture will come to the remembrance of an individual and the word will be built around that particular passage…
- A few sentences will be revealed and the rest will come as the individual obediently speaks what has been given to him…
- An entire line of thought will be revealed all the individual has to do is say exactly what he has been given to say…
- On very rare occasions a person may not know at all what they are about to say, they just give the Spirit a voice to speak the message of God… (My personal

experience in Fouke) It is my opinion that no one except the Pastor should engage in such a risky practice)

As with all other gifts, interpretation of tongues requires obedience to be mixed with faith in the successful implementation of the proper operation of this gift.

PRACTICAL APPLICATION:
The following guidelines should be adhered to in the operation of this very important gift:

- The individual should pray to know the voice of the Holy Spirit…
- The individual should be absolutely certain they have heard from God before they speak…
- The individual should make certain their words line up completely with Scripture…

- The individual should wait to begin the interpretation until the message in tongues has been completed…
- The individual should give the interpretation as quickly as possible following the completion of the message in tongues…
- The Individual should always give the interpretation in the third person, rather than the first or second person… Rather than saying *"I the Lord"* or *"Thus says the Lord"* the individual should say, *"The Lord would have you to know."*
- The individual should not prolong the message by attempting to insert their own interpretation; they should say what has been revealed; nothing more, nothing less…

THE GIFTS OF THE SPIRIT
1 Corinthians 12:1-11

PROPHECY - Vs. 10

The gift we are about to study is a very important gift in the life of the corporate church and the individual believer. Participation in this particular gift is encouraged in Scripture more than any of the others. Various forms of the word prophecy are used twenty-two times in the four chapters surrounding our text (chapters 11-14).

To most people the gift of prophecy is too complex to delve into, therefore they ignore it all together. To ignore this very important gift is to miss out completely on something wonderful God has provided for the edification, exhortation, and comfort of the corporate church body, and the confirmation of direction for the individual believer.

In an effort to better understand the purpose and proper operation of this wonderful gift, the following things must be completely understood by the individual believer:
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The gift of prophecy and the office of a Prophet are two different gifts that oftentimes are resident within the same believer…
- The office of a Prophet is one of the five-fold ministry gifts given to the church… Ephesians 4:11-12 (NKJV) ***"And He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers, 12 for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ."***
- The gift of prophecy is one of the nine spiritual gifts given to the general church body; it is listed sixth among spiritual gifts…

- The office of Prophet is listed second among ministry gifts…
- The gift of prophecy is not relegated to certain individuals – All the Lord's people are capable of prophesying. I Corinthians 14:1, 5, 24 & 31 The Prophet Joel stated that our ***"Sons and daughters would prophesy."*** (Joel 2:28)
- The office of Prophet is always tied to a particular individual…
- The gift of prophecy does not carry with it the component of prediction except in the sense of confirming what God has already revealed to the individual…
- When prediction is employed at least three gifts are being pressed into service at the same time: the word of wisdom, the word of knowledge, and prophecy…
- The gift of prophecy does not indicate the person through whom the gift is flowing is a Prophet…
- The office of a Prophet always utilizes the gift of prophecy…

- The predictions of Old Testament Prophets differ from New Testament Prophets in the fact that the Prophets in the Old Testament predicted things the people did not have a clue about…
- The predictions of New Testament Prophets only confirm direction to the believer. The words of each prophecy will always line up with the written Word of God…
- In the Old Testament the general public did not have the advantage of the written Word or the witness of the Holy Spirit…
- The New Testament believer has the advantage of the written Word as well as the ability to have a personal relationship with God through the Holy Spirit… We also have the added benefit of His work in our life and spiritual walk.
- Neither the words of a prophecy, nor the words of a Prophet should ever carry as much weight or authority as the written Word of God…

- When the words of a prophecy conflict with the written Word or the witness of the believer's spirit, the words are to be set aside…
- When the words of a Prophet conflict with the written Word or the witness of the believer's spirit, the words are to be set aside…

The difference between the gift of prophecy and the office of a Prophet can be clearly discovered by defining both words. The word Prophet comes from two Hebrew words: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Naba… (Naw-baw) Meaning - To speak or sing by inspiration in prediction or simple disclosure…
- Nabiy'… (Naw-bee') Meaning - An inspired person… So the word Prophet means an individual who is inspired of God to speak or sing predictions or to make disclosures.

In order to fully understand this gift one must take into consideration four Greek terms: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Pro, meaning fore, which means in front of or prior to…
- Phemi (Fay-mee'), meaning to show or make known ones thoughts…
- Prophetes (Prof-ay'-tace), an inspired speaker…
- Propheteia (Prof-ay-ti'-ah), meaning prediction…

So the word prophecy means to be inspired to make known ones thoughts without any prior prompting. The only element of prediction indicated here is in confirming to the individual what God has already spoken to them.

In the interest of time, the focus of our study will not allow us to completely define the

office of the Prophet, but rather will focus on the gift of prophecy.

The gift of prophecy has three specific components that cause this gift to benefit the corporate church as well as the individual believer. 1 Corinthians 14:1-3 (KJV) ***"Follow after charity, and desire spiritual gifts, but rather that ye may prophesy. 2 For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue speaketh not unto men, but unto God: for no man understandeth him; howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries. 3 But he that prophesieth speaketh unto men to edification, and exhortation, and comfort."***

Let's take a look at these three words and how they affect this gift and its operation: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Edification… This word comes from the Greek word Oikodome (Oy-kod-om-ay'), meaning to build up in the same

way an architect would visualize, draft, and oversee the plans of a building.

- Exhortation… This word comes from the Greek word Paraklesia (Par-ak'-lay-sis), meaning to inspire, invite, invoke, to call near.
- Comfort… This word comes from the Greek word Paramuthia (Par-am-oo-thee'-ah), meaning consolation or words of encouragement.

This aspect of the gift is often employed when the church or individual believer is enduring times of distress.

By definition, the operation of this gift should encourage, inspire and build up the church or individual in the same way an architect would visualize, plan and oversee the construction of a building.

It should be noted that in the New Testament, this gift never carried with it the

element of correction! The office of the Old Testament Prophet certainly encompassed the responsibility of correction, but in the New Testament that responsibility is solely the responsibility of the Pastor. The only person who has the right to correct a church is the Pastor of that church!

As we have already discovered, the gift of prophecy is available to all who have been baptized in the Holy Spirit, but the office of Prophet is more narrowly defined as that of an individual whose primary purpose is to prophesy. When a Prophet prophesies, his prophecy almost always carries with it the element of prediction.

Occasionally those who fit into one of the five ministry gifts as defined in Ephesians 4 (Apostle, Prophet, Evangelist, Pastor, Teacher) will be used in the gift of prophecy as defined in 1 Corinthians 12. Because a

person has been used in this way does not necessarily make them a Prophet.

A good example of this is my primary ministry gift is an Apostle. An Apostle is someone who initiates ministries and oversees the ministry of others. While I am primarily an Apostle, that gift has found its expression through the office of Pastor. While I have at times functioned in the prophetic, been an evangelist and teacher, my dominant ministry gift is that of an Apostle,

Does the fact that I have occasionally flowed in the other ministry gifts make me a a Prophet? An Evangelist? A Teacher? No, I am an Apostle who is the Pastor of a local congregation! It has been necessary for me to flow in the other ministry gifts, but when that has occurred, it has been to enhance my ability to fulfill my primary role of being an Apostle.

I think we could accurately say that just because a person prophesies from time to time does not make them a Prophet.

As is the case with all the other gifts, this gift is to be regulated and judged. We will discuss in detail the regulations for this gift as we conclude this lesson.

The proper judgment of this gift should be handled according to the following pattern: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- All words of prophecy must line up with the written Word of God…
- All prophecy must be given in the right spirit with the right attitude…
- All prophecy must carry with it the elements of edification, exhortation, and comfort…
- A prophecy should never carry with it the element of correction unless it comes through the Pastor of the church…

- If a person gives a prophecy that is out of order or does not line up with the aforementioned guidelines, the Pastor of the church should be the one to deal with the individual…
- If an inappropriate prophecy is given it does not necessarily mean that the person is a false Prophet… Deuteronomy 18:22 (NKJV) ***"When a prophet speaks in the name of the LORD, if the thing does not happen or come to pass, that is the thing which the LORD has not spoken; the prophet has spoken it presumptuously; you shall not be afraid of him."***

The receiving and giving of a prophecy is very similar to the gift of interpretation of tongues.

A prophecy can be received in the following ways: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- A Scripture will come to the remembrance of an individual and the word will be built around that particular passage…
- A few sentences will be revealed and the rest will come as the individual obediently speaks what has been given to him…
- An entire line of thought will be revealed; all the individual has to do is say exactly what he has been given to say…
- On very rare occasions a person may not know at all what they are about to say, they just give the Spirit a voice to speak the message of God. It is my opinion that no one except the Pastor should engage in such a risky practice…
- Prophecy requires obedience to be mixed with faith in the successful implementation of the proper operation of this gift…

It should be said that oftentimes a word of prophecy will only be completely understood by those for whom it is intended.

PRACTICAL APPLICATION:

The following regulations should be adhered to in the operation of this very important gift: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The individual should pray to know the voice of the Holy Spirit…
- The individual should be absolutely certain they have heard from God before they speak…
- The individual should make certain their words line up completely with Scripture…
- The individual should be sensitive to the element of timing within the context of the meeting…
- The Individual should always give the prophecy in the third person, rather than the first or second person… Rather than

saying ***"I the Lord would say"*** or ***"Thus says the Lord,"*** the individual should say ***"The Lord would have you to know."***

- The individual should not prolong the prophecy by attempting to insert their own words; they should say what has been revealed - nothing more, nothing less…

As with tongues and interpretation of tongues, the Scriptural limitation of two or three prophesies per meeting should be observed. 1 Corinthians 14:29 (NKJV) ***"Let two or three prophets speak, and let the others judge."*** (This regulation has to do with prophecies spoken over the corporate church – This has nothing to do with prophecies spoken over individuals at the altar)

Regulations are given to encourage the frequency of the proper use of these gifts not to suppress them.

THE GIFTS OF THE SPIRIT
1 Corinthians 12:1-11

MAKING THE GIFTS WORK
1 Corinthians 13:1-13 (NKJV) ***"Though I speak with the tongues of men and of angels, but have not love, I have become sounding brass or a clanging cymbal.2 And though I have the gift of prophecy, and understand all mysteries and all knowledge, and though I have all faith, so that I could remove mountains, but have not love, I am nothing.3 And though I bestow all my goods to feed the poor, and though I give my body to be burned, but have not love, it profits me nothing. 4 Love suffers long and is kind; love does not envy; love does not parade itself, is not puffed up;5 does not behave rudely, does not seek its own, is not provoked, thinks no evil;6 does not rejoice in iniquity, but rejoices in the truth;7 bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things,***

endures all things.8 Love never fails. But whether there are prophecies, they will fail; whether there are tongues, they will cease; whether there is knowledge, it will vanish away.9 For we know in part and we prophesy in part.10 But when that which is perfect has come, then that which is in part will be done away.11 When I was a child, I spoke as a child, I understood as a child, I thought as a child; but when I became a man, I put away childish things.12 For now we see in a mirror, dimly, but then face to face. Now I know in part, but then I shall know just as I also am known.13 And now abide faith, hope, love, these three; but the greatest of these is love."

In the last several weeks, we have studied nine of the wonderful gifts God has provided for the encouragement, exhortation and comfort of the individual believer, as well as that of the corporate body of Christ:

- The word of wisdom…

- The word of knowledge…
- Discerning of spirits…
- The gift of faith…
- The gifts of healings…
- The gift of miracles…
- The gift of tongues…
- Interpretation of tongues…
- The gift of prophecy…

While each of these gifts are extremely important to the spiritual well being of the body of Christ, there is one character trait that is to be desired above all else, and that is Love. We will not spend an exorbitant amount of time defining love in this lesson, as we will begin studying the fruit of the spirit within the next several weeks.

There are several kinds of love but the love we will be discussing here will be agape love, which is an undeserved, selfless love. Agape love is the love God has displayed in His relationship with man. Agape love is the

love we have been commanded to shower upon everyone within our circle of influence.

The focus of this lesson will be the effect of love on the operation of the gifts of the Spirit. Contrary to popular belief, Love is not something we are born with or without. It is a choice! The acquisition of the capability to truly offer love comes through a choice; the choice to accept the love of God! John 3:16 (NKJV) ***"For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life."***

Once we become a believer, we choose to love others or elect to withhold love. We are commanded in Scripture to dispense that which we have received. Matthew 10:5-8 (NKJV) ***"These twelve Jesus sent out and commanded them, saying: "Do not go into the way of the Gentiles, and do not enter a***

city of the Samaritans.6 "But go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.7 "And as you go, preach, saying, 'The kingdom of heaven is at hand.'8 "Heal the sick, cleanse the lepers, raise the dead, cast out demons. Freely you have received, freely give." To receive unconditional love and fail to dispense it is no doubt a sin. As a believer, we are genetically engineered to be rivers rather than reservoirs.

The love of God will produce at least three things in the life of the believer: Matthew 22:37-40 **(NKJV)** ***"Jesus said to him, "You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your mind.'38 "This is the first and great commandment.39 "And the second is like it: 'You shall love your neighbor as yourself.'40 "On these two commandments hang all the Law and the Prophets."***
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Love for God…

- Love for self… If one does not have self-love he rejects the crowning creation of God.
- Love for others… It is not possible for one to love others more than one loves himself.

I want us to look closely at how spiritual gifts and love are interrelated. In 1 Corinthians 12, Paul introduces the gifts; in 1 Corinthians 14 he regulates and sets boundaries for the proper operation of the gifts. It is no accident that 1 Corinthians 13, which deals exclusively with love, ties the two chapters together.

Paul states in a very confident way that to operate in a gift while failing to walk in love is not only futile, but also counterproductive. 1 Corinthians 13:1-3 (NKJV) ***"Though I speak with the tongues of men and of angels, but have not love, I have become sounding brass or a clanging cymbal.2 And***

though I have the gift of prophecy, and understand all mysteries and all knowledge, and though I have all faith, so that I could remove mountains, but <u>have not love</u>, <u>I am nothing</u>.3 And though I bestow all my goods to feed the poor, and though I give my body to be burned, but <u>have not love</u>, <u>it profits me nothing</u>."

While gifts are necessary and even imperative to the believer and the corporate body of the church, they will never accomplish the purpose God has in mind unless the gift is accompanied by love.

Some reasons love is so important to the successful operation of the gifts include:
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- When one does not walk in love, people will not receive the <u>message</u> of the gift…
- When one does not walk in love, people will <u>reject</u> the gifts…

- When one does not walk in love, the gift becomes tarnished in the spirit of the carrier of the gift…
- When one does not walk in love, the delivery of the gift tends to be abrasive…
- When one does not walk in love, the gift will not flow long term…
- When one does not walk in love, the tendency is to attempt to operate the gift through the flesh…

Love is the element that bridges the gap between a gift and its proper operation. Love causes the gift to be plausible and acceptable. Without love the gifts will be detested and possibly even discarded.

How do we to know whether we are walking in love? (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Love is patient with people…

- Love is kind and good… Showing and showering favors.
- Love does not allow for envy or jealousy…
- Love does not brag or seek recognition from others…
- Love does not feel or act better than others…
- Love is not rude…
- Love is not touchy or quick tempered…
- Love does not keep record of wrongs done…
- Love allows for no gloating over the wrongdoing or misfortune of others…
- Love is satisfied only with truth…
- Love is sturdy under heavy responsibility and is willing to cover for weaker Christians…
- Love chooses to trust…
- Love believes the best in all situations…
- Love never loses hope…
- Love remains faithful in spite of repeated attacks…

- Love never quits…
- Love is perfect and complete…
- Love displays maturity rather than immaturity…
- Love handles others as if it were handling God…

PRACTICAL APPLICATION:
If we desire to operate in the giftedness of God and do so at the highest level of effectiveness possible, we must do the following things: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Make a choice to love God with our whole heart; love our self as the crowning creation of God; love others with the same level of intensity as we love ourselves.
- Constantly take inventory of our lives to make sure we are walking in the love of God, bearing in mind that the effectiveness of the gift can be hampered by a deficiency of love.

- Make a commitment to allow the components of love not only to be present, but dominant in our lives.

Remember, no matter how many gifts seem to operate in our lives, if we do not have love as a companion we will never accomplish all the giver of the gift intended.

If you and I are to be used of God to distribute His gifts to His children, we must speak and act in the spirit of the Giver. To do the work of God, we must operate in the Spirit of God. We must distribute His gifts in love.

Is it reasonable to assume that a God of love, who desires to gift a gift to a child He loves, would not put His gift at the disposal of a person who acts harshly, speaks critically, seeks to take credit for the outcome, and misrepresents the intent and heart of a loving Father.